



Horizon Europe

European Research Council (ERC)

Frontier Research Grants

Information for Applicants to the
Starting and Consolidator Grant Calls



European Research Council
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Established by the European Commission

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Information for Applicants to the Starting and Consolidator Grant 2027 Calls



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Main changes in 2027:

- ***Additional funding will continue to be provided to Principal Investigators who are re-locating to the EU or an Associated Country from elsewhere to take up their ERC grant. This additional funding may be up to EUR 2 000 000.***
- ***Eligibility periods: Applicants who defended their PhD in the ten-year period preceding the 1st of January 2027 are eligible for a Starting Grant. Applicants who defended their PhD between five and fifteen years prior to the 1st January 2027 are eligible for a Consolidator Grant.***
- ***Resubmission restrictions: Principal Investigators who held a Starting or Consolidator Grant in the past cannot re-apply for the same type of Grant. Additional restrictions will apply to Principal Investigators who have participated in previous evaluations. Detailed information on these can be found in [section 1.2](#).***

IMPORTANT TO NOTE

The present document is based on the legal documents setting the rules and conditions for the ERC frontier research grants, in particular:

- the [ERC Work Programme 2027¹](#),
- the European Research Council rules of submission, and the related methods and procedures for peer review and proposal evaluation relevant to the specific programme implementing [Horizon Europe](#) (hereinafter ERC Rules of Submission and Evaluation under Horizon Europe), and
- the [Model Grant Agreement used for ERC actions²](#).

This document complements and does not supersede the afore-mentioned documents, which are legally binding and prevail in case of discrepancies. The European Commission, the ERC Executive Agency or any person or body acting on their behalf cannot be held responsible for the use made of this document.

The [Guide for ERC Peer Reviewers](#) applicable to Starting and Consolidator grant calls, provides practical information on the evaluation process.

National Contact Points (ERC NCPs) have been set up across Europe³ by the national governments to provide information and personalised support to ERC applicants in their native language. The mission of the ERC NCPs is to raise awareness, inform and advise on ERC funding opportunities as well as to support potential applicants in the preparation, submission and follow-up of ERC grant applications. For details on the ERC NCP in your country, please consult the [ERC website](#) or the [EU Funding & Tenders Portal](#).

For any questions related to the call, please contact the relevant Call coordination team: ERC-2027-STG-APPLICANTS@ec.europa.eu or ERC-2027-COG-APPLICANTS@ec.europa.eu

Abbreviations

AI – Artificial Intelligence	HE - Horizon Europe Framework Programme
AC - Associated Country ⁴	
ADG - Advanced Grant	HI - Host institution
COG - Consolidator Grant	PI - Principal Investigator
ERC - European Research Council	PM - Panel Member
ERC WP - ERC Work Programme	PIC - Participant Identification Code
ERC panel - ERC peer review evaluation panel	SEP - Submission and Evaluation of Proposals (online tool)
ERC NCP - ERC National Contact Points	STG - Starting Grant
ERCEA - ERC Executive Agency	SYG - Synergy Grant
EU MS - EU Member States	ScC - ERC Scientific Council
F&T Portal - EU Funding & Tenders Portal [Single Electronic Data Interchange Area (SEDIA)]	

¹ European Commission C(2026) 4907 of 20 July 2026.

² Specific rules for ERC actions are detailed in Annex 5 of the Horizon Europe General Model Grant Agreement.

³ This applies to EU Member States and Associated Countries. Some other countries also provide this service.

⁴ Please check the Horizon Europe Programme Guide on the [EU Funding & Tenders Portal](#) for up-to-date information on the current position for Associated Countries.

Content

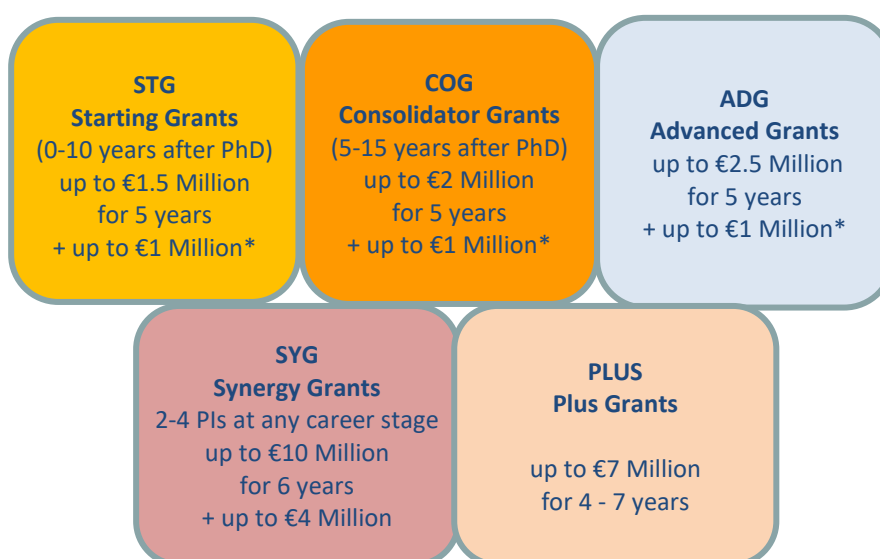
1. ERC STARTING AND CONSOLIDATOR GRANTS 2027	6
1.1 ERC FUNDING PRINCIPLES	6
1.2 ADMISSIBILITY AND ELIGIBILITY	9
1.3 EVALUATION PROCESS.....	13
1.4 ETHICS AND SECURITY	19
1.5 MEANS OF REDRESS, ENQUIRIES AND COMPLAINTS.....	21
1.6 QUESTIONS RELATED TO THE CALL	23
2. COMPLETING AN APPLICATION	24
2.1 OVERVIEW OF AN ERC APPLICATION.....	24
2.2 THE ADMINISTRATIVE FORM	24
2.3 THE RESEARCH PROPOSAL	27
2.4 SUPPORTING DOCUMENTATION	32
3. SUBMITTING AN APPLICATION	34
3.1 IMPORTANT INFORMATION.....	34
3.2 HOW TO APPLY.....	35
3.3 HOW TO WITHDRAW A PROPOSAL	38
4. ANNEXES	39
4.1 ERC EVALUATION PANELS AND KEYWORDS.....	39
4.2 HOST INSTITUTION SUPPORT LETTER TEMPLATE 2027.....	51
4.3 PHD AND EQUIVALENT DOCTORAL DEGREES.....	54
4.4 SUPPORTING DOCUMENTS FOR THE PHD REFERENCE DATE AND EXTENSION REQUESTS.....	57
4.5 ADDITIONAL SECURITY CONDITIONS FOR ELIGIBILITY	62
4.6 LIST OF BLOCKING FIELDS IN THE ONLINE SUBMISSION FORM	63
4.7 PROPOSAL BUDGET REPORT	65
4.8 TEMPLATE FOR REQUESTING ELIGIBILITY EXTENSION	67
4.9 TEMPLATE TO BE FILLED IN BY THE PHD AWARDING INSTITUTION CONFIRMING THE PHD DEFENCE DATE	68
4.10 DATA PROTECTION NOTICE.....	69

1. ERC STARTING AND CONSOLIDATOR GRANTS 2027

1.1 ERC FUNDING PRINCIPLES

The ERC Starting and Consolidator Grants are part of the main ERC frontier research grants 2027 funded by the European Union's Horizon Europe Framework Programme for Research and Innovation.

The ERC's main frontier research grants aim to empower individual researchers and provide the best settings to foster their creativity. **Scientific excellence** is the sole criterion of evaluation. Please see below an overview of all ERC 2027 main frontier research calls.



*Except for Principal Investigators in the Starting, Consolidator, or Advanced Grant calls re-locating to the EU or an Associated Country from elsewhere to take up their ERC grant. In this case, the additional funding may be up to €2 Million.

Single Principal Investigator (PI) heading a research team

The ERC Starting and Consolidator grants support individual researchers that are starting or consolidating their own independent research team or programme, and who can demonstrate the ground-breaking nature and ambition of their scientific proposal. In certain fields (e.g. in the humanities and mathematics), where research is often performed individually, the 'team' may consist solely of the Principal Investigator.

Research fields – no predetermined priorities

The ERC's frontier research grants operate on a 'bottom-up' basis and applications can be made in any field of research with an emphasis on the frontiers of science, scholarship and engineering⁵. In particular, the ERC welcomes proposals of interdisciplinary nature, which cross the boundaries between different fields of research, pioneering proposals addressing new and emerging fields of research or proposals introducing unconventional, innovative approaches and scientific inventions.

⁵ Research proposals within the scope of Annex I to the Euratom Treaty, namely those directed towards nuclear energy applications shall be submitted to relevant calls under the [Euratom Research and Training Programme](#).

The focus is on the Principal Investigator and on the individual team. Support for consortia⁶ is provided by other calls under Horizon Europe. Projects wholly or largely consisting of the collation and compilation of existing material in new databases, editions or collections are unlikely to constitute ground-breaking or frontier research, however useful such resources might be to subsequent original research. Such projects are therefore unlikely to be recommended for funding by the ERC panels. As ERC funds frontier research, careful consideration should be given so to propose truly novel ideas, not just continuations of ongoing work or existing collaboration.

Evaluation and peer review

The ERC's evaluation process is conducted by peer review panels composed of independent external experts who are renowned scientists and scholars. The panel chair and members are selected by the ERC Scientific Council on the basis of their scientific merits. The panels may be assisted by other independent external experts working remotely.

Open Science

Open science is a general principle of the Horizon Europe programme, and a core principle of the ERC. The ERC is committed to the principle of open access to the published output of research, including, in particular, peer-reviewed articles and monographs. It also supports the basic principle of open access to research data and data-related products such as computer code, algorithms, software, workflows, protocols, electronic notebooks or any other forms of research output. The ERC considers that providing free online access to all these materials can be the most effective way of ensuring that the results of the research it funds can be accessed, read and used as the basis for further advancement.

Under Horizon Europe, beneficiaries of ERC grants must ensure immediate open access to all peer-reviewed scientific publications⁷ related to their results as set out in the Annex 5 of the applicable [Model Grant Agreement](#) used for ERC actions. Open access has to be provided with full re-use rights⁸. Beneficiaries must ensure that they or the authors retain sufficient intellectual property rights to comply with their open access requirements and the grant agreement obligations⁹. Publishing costs can be considered as eligible costs provided that the publishing venue (e.g. journal, book) is fully open access.

The provisions on research data management of the MGA Annex 5 (for ERC actions) will apply to beneficiaries funded under the [ERC Work Programme 2027](#).

In particular, whenever a project generates research data, beneficiaries are required to manage it in line with the principles of findability, accessibility, interoperability, and reusability as described by

⁶ Consortium agreements are not required for ERC multi-beneficiary grants, as the [Starting, Consolidator, and Advanced Grants will support projects carried out by individual teams, which are headed by a single Principal Investigator](#). The ERC Synergy Grant Groups are neither networks nor consortia of undertakings, universities, research centres, or other legal entities. Even though Consortium agreements are not required, beneficiaries must have internal arrangements regarding their operation and coordination, to ensure that the action is implemented properly (article 7 of the MGA). These internal arrangements must cover the decision-making procedures for scientific and grant management issues, the distribution of the EU contribution, internal dispute settlement and division of responsibilities for cases of rejection of costs or reduction of the grant.

⁷ This includes peer-reviewed book chapters and long-text publications such as monographs, edited collections, critical editions, scholarly exhibition catalogues, or PhD theses.

⁸ For monographs and other long-text formats, the licence may exclude commercial re-use and derivative works e.g. CC BY-NC, CC BY-ND) (as specified in the [Annex 5 of the applicable Model Grant Agreement for ERC Actions under Horizon Europe](#))

⁹ The granting authority may, up to four years after the end of the action, object to a transfer of ownership or to the exclusive licensing of results, as set out in the specific provision of Annex 5 of the applicable Model Grant Agreement used for ERC actions. If requested by the granting authority, additional obligations to grant non-exclusive licences for the exploitation of results apply to the beneficiaries of ERC frontier research grants in case of a public emergency (applicable up to four years after the end of the action).

the FAIR principles' initiative¹⁰, and establish a data management plan within the first six months of project implementation. Open access to research data should be ensured under the principle 'as open as possible, as closed as necessary'. These provisions are designed to facilitate access, re-use and preservation of the research data generated during the ERC funded research work.

Funding

Starting Grants can be up to a maximum of EUR 1 500 000 for a period of 5 years. Consolidator Grants can be up to a maximum of EUR 2 000 000 for a period of 5 years. For projects of shorter duration, the maximum amount of the grant is reduced pro rata¹¹.

Additional funding up to EUR 1 000 000 can be requested in the proposal for STG and COG by applicants already based in an EU Member State or associated country to cover further eligible costs for any cost category when these are necessary to carry out the proposed work (all eligible costs in line with the eligibility conditions for HE projects listed in art 6.1 of the [HE Annotated Model Grant Agreement](#)). The request for additional funding must be duly justified in the proposal.

Researchers based outside the EU or Associated Countries⁴ at the time of the call deadline and applying for a Starting or Consolidator Grant can request up to EUR 2 000 000 in additional funding to cover further eligible costs necessary for the project implementation.

The requests for additional funding must be duly justified in the proposal. Additional funding is not subject to pro rata temporis reduction for projects of shorter duration¹². All funding requested is assessed during evaluation.

Eligible project costs will be reimbursed at a funding rate of 100% for direct costs plus a flat-rate of 25% for indirect costs¹³.

Research integrity¹⁴

Breaches of research integrity, including scientific misconduct such as fabrication, falsification, plagiarism or misrepresentation of data¹⁵, as well as contacts with any independent external expert involved in the peer review evaluation (peer reviewers) in the attempt to influence its outcome, which may arise during the evaluation or the granting process, may result in the rejection of proposals from the current call and in a possible restriction on submission of proposals to future calls, as provided in the relevant ERC Work Programme¹⁶. Please also note that a plagiarism detection software is used to analyse all submitted proposals in order to detect similar proposals submitted by different Principal Investigators. A procedure is in place to assess alleged or suspected cases of scientific misconduct.

¹⁰ [The FAIR Guiding Principles for scientific data management and stewardship.](#)

¹¹ This does not apply to ongoing projects.

¹² The maximum award is reduced pro rata temporis for projects of a shorter duration (e.g. for a Consolidator Grant project of 48 months duration the maximum requested EU contribution allowed is 1.600.000 €). Additional is not subject to pro-rata temporis reduction for projects of shorter duration (e.g. for COG PIs already residing in EU/AC with additional funding it is possible to request a maximum EU contribution of 2.600.000 € for a project of 48 months duration).

¹³ Excluding the direct eligible costs for subcontracting and internally invoiced goods and services.

¹⁴ See also section 1.3 of this document.

¹⁵ For example, if (i) in the list of publications, the order of authors does not appear as indicated in the original publications; (ii) the written consent of the research collaborators mentioned in the proposal is not obtained before the call submission deadline.

¹⁶ See section 3.11 of the [ERC Rules of submission and evaluation under Horizon Europe.](#)

Starting and Consolidator Grant profiles

Principal Investigator must provide a list of achievements reflecting their track record. A short narrative describing the scientific importance of the research outputs, and the role played by the Principal Investigator in their production may also be included.

Applicants are encouraged to evaluate their track record and research independence against the below-mentioned benchmarks, in order to judge their likelihood for success and to avoid investing efforts in proposals that are very unlikely to succeed.

Starting Grant	Consolidator Grant
A competitive Starting Grant Principal Investigator should have already shown evidence of the potential for research independence, for example by having produced at least one important publication as main author or without the participation of their PhD supervisor.	A competitive Consolidator Grant Principal Investigator should have already shown evidence of research independence.

1.2 ADMISSIBILITY AND ELIGIBILITY

Admissible and eligible proposals

All proposals must be complete, readable, and accessible. A complete proposal should contain all parts and sections, as defined in the [ERC Work Programme 2027](#). They must be submitted electronically by eligible Principal Investigators before the relevant call deadlines. The proposal must also satisfy the requirements set out in the documents referenced in the call for proposals. Please see [section 2.1](#) for an overview of a complete ERC proposal. Proposals that do not meet these criteria may be declared inadmissible. All scientific fields are eligible for ERC funding⁵.

All applications and the related supporting information are reviewed to ensure that all admissibility and eligibility criteria are met. The proposal's content should be related to the objectives of the Starting and Consolidator Grant calls and must meet all admissibility and eligibility requirements as defined in the [ERC Work Programme 2027](#). Where there is a doubt about the admissibility or eligibility of a proposal, the peer review evaluation may proceed pending a decision of the Responsible Authorising Officer following the opinion of the admissibility and eligibility review committee. The fact that a proposal is evaluated in such circumstances does not constitute a proof of its admissibility or eligibility. If it becomes clear before, during, or after the peer review evaluation phase, that one or more of the admissibility or eligibility criteria has not been met (for example, due to incorrect or misleading information), the proposal will be declared inadmissible or ineligible and it will be rejected.

Host institution

The host institution must engage the Principal Investigator for at least the duration of the project, as defined in the grant agreement¹⁷. It must either be established in an EU Member State (EU MS) or Associated Country (AC)⁴ as a legal entity created under national law, or it may be an international European research organisation (such as CERN, EMBL, etc.), or any other entity created under EU law. International organisations with headquarters in an EU MS or AC will be deemed to be

¹⁷ Model Grant Agreement used for ERC actions.

established in this EU MS or AC. Any type of legal entity, public or private, including universities, research organisations and undertakings can host Principal Investigators and their teams.

To be eligible, legal entities from an EU MS or AC that are public bodies, research organisations or higher education institutions (including private research organisations and private higher education institutions) must have a gender equality plan (GEP) or an equivalent strategic document in place for the duration of the project. The GEP or equivalent must fulfil the mandatory requirements listed in Annex 5 of the [ERC WP 2027](#). The ERC welcomes applications from Principal Investigators hosted by private for profit research centres, including industrial laboratories. Normally, the Principal Investigator will be employed by the host institution, but cases where, for duly justified reasons, the Principal Investigator's employer cannot become the host institution, or where the Principal Investigator is self-employed, can be accommodated. The specific conditions of engagement will be subject to clarification and approval during the granting procedure or during the amendment procedure for a change of host institution. During the granting process, the necessary verifications of applicant legal entities¹⁸ will take place, including the assessment of their financial capacity, if required¹⁹.

The HI must confirm its association with, and its support to, the project and the Principal Investigator through a binding statement of support (i.e. the Host Institution Support Letter). This statement must be provided at the time of application. Proposals that do not include a statement of support may be declared inadmissible.

Principal Investigator

ERC grants are open to researchers of any nationality who intend to conduct their research activity in any EU MS or an AC⁴. The research team may be of national or trans-national character. The Principal Investigator does not need to be employed by the host institution at the time when the proposal is submitted. If not already employed by the host institution, the Principal Investigator must be engaged by the latter at least for the duration of the grant. Grant proposals are submitted by the Principal Investigator who takes scientific responsibility for the project, on behalf of the host institution.

In order to be eligible to apply to the ERC Starting or Consolidator Grant, a Principal Investigator must hold a PhD or an equivalent doctoral degree. The reference date used for calculation of the eligibility period should be the date of the successful defence of the **first** PhD (or equivalent doctoral degree)²⁰. In case the Principal Investigator holds more than one PhD degree, the defence date of the first PhD is always considered as the starting point of the eligibility window, irrespective of the research field (see [Annex 4.3](#) for further details). The ERC policy on PhD and equivalent doctoral degrees, including specific provisions for holders of medical degrees, is provided in [Annex 4.3](#).

¹⁸ Applicant legal entities that are subject to the administrative sanction of exclusion or are in one of the exclusion situations set out in the [Regulation \(EU, Euratom\) 2024/2509 of the European Parliament and of the Council](#) ('the EU Financial Regulation') are banned from receiving EU grants and cannot participate. Please see Articles 138 and 143 of the EU Financial Regulation, section 4.5, as well as important information on possible exclusion and registration of economic operators in the Commission's Early Detection and Exclusion System (EDES) on the final page of the ERC Work Programme 2027.

¹⁹ Applicant legal entities must have stable and sufficient resources to successfully implement the projects and contribute their share. Organisations participating in several projects must have sufficient capacity to implement all these projects. Information on financial capacity checks is provided in the ERC Rules of submission and evaluation under Horizon Europe.

²⁰ See section 2.4 Supporting documentation for cases where there was no defence of the PhD or if following the defence, corrections were required.

Starting Grant	Consolidator Grant
The first PhD shall have been successfully defended > 0 and ≤ 10 years prior to 1 January 2027 Cut-off dates: Successful defence of first PhD from 1 January 2017 to 31 December 2026 (inclusive)	The first PhD shall have been successfully defended > 5 and ≤ 15 years prior to 1 January 2027 Cut-off dates: Successful defence of first PhD from 1 January 2012 to 31 December 2021 (inclusive)

The eligibility periods set out in the table above can be extended beyond 10 and 15 years for the Starting and Consolidator Grants, respectively, for certain properly documented circumstances such as for maternity and paternity leaves, clinical training, long-term illness, disability, national service, major disaster, seeking asylum, gender-based violence or any other form of violence (see [Annex 4.4](#) for further details).

Further explanation on the eligibility windows

Example 1

An applicant has finished working on the PhD project in March 2026 and the PhD defence is scheduled on 15 October 2026. As the applicant will not hold a PhD degree or equivalent at the time of the Starting Grant call deadline (14 October 2026), the applicant is not eligible for the Starting Grant 2027 call.

Example 2

An applicant defended the PhD on 1 January 2019. As the defence occurred 8 years prior to 1 January 2027, the applicant is eligible to apply to the Starting Grant 2027 call (0-10 years after the PhD) or to the Consolidator Grant 2027 call (5-15 years after the PhD).

Expected time commitment²¹

With the support of the host institution, the successful Principal Investigators are expected to lead their individual teams and devote a significant amount of time to the project. They will be expected to spend a minimum of 50% for STG and 40% for COG of their working time on the ERC project and a minimum of 50% of their working time in an EU MS or an AC²². It is expected that the research project will be implemented within the territory of the Member States or Associated Countries. This does not exclude field work or other research activities in cases where these must necessarily be conducted outside the European Union or the Associated Countries in order to achieve the scientific objectives of the project/activity.

²¹ For further guidance, see the [Annotated Grant Agreement](#) on the EU Funding & Tenders Portal (Annex 5, section Specific rules for ERC Grants (HE), point 5. PI time commitments).

²² For Principal Investigators hosted and engaged by international European research organisations, any time spent working for these organisations may count as working time spent in a Member State or an Associated Country for the purpose of the Principal Investigator's time commitment.

Submission restrictions

Thousands of high-quality proposals are received each year and only outstanding proposals are likely to be funded. In order to maintain the quality and integrity of ERC's evaluation process, restrictions on applications have been put in place.

The following general restrictions apply:

- A Principal Investigator may have only one proposal to an ERC main grant call under evaluation²³ at any given time;
- A Principal Investigator may submit only one eligible proposal to an ERC main grant call published under the ERC Work Programme 2027;
- A Principal Investigator may hold only one ERC main grant at any given time^{24 25}
- An applicant, whose proposal has been selected for funding and who is preparing a grant agreement under a call of the ERC Work Programme 2025 or 2026, may not apply for an ERC main grant call under the ERC Work Programme 2027;
- A Principal Investigator in one of the ERC main frontier research grants may not submit another proposal for an ERC main frontier research grant, unless the existing project ends²⁶ less than two years following the call deadline²⁷;
- A Principal Investigator who has held an ERC Starting Grant cannot apply for a Starting Grant call under the ERC Work Programme 2027;
- A Principal Investigator who has held an ERC Consolidator Grant cannot apply for a Consolidator Grant call under the ERC Work Programme 2027;
- A researcher who is a serving Panel Member for an ERC call under the Work Programme 2027 or who served as a Panel Member for an ERC call under Work Programme 2025 may not apply to a call for the same type of main frontier research grant under the ERC Work Programme 2027²⁸;
- If a researcher applies to more than one main ERC frontier research grant call published under the same Work Programme (i.e. from the same 'call year'), only the first eligible proposal will be evaluated;

Additional restrictions are related to the outcome of the evaluation in previous calls (see table below). Inadmissible, ineligible or withdrawn proposals do not count against any of the restrictions listed below.

²³ A proposal is considered as being under evaluation from the time of the call deadline until the time when the applicant receives a letter informing them of either the outcome of the admissibility or eligibility check or of the outcome of the evaluation. The latter includes a letter informing the applicant that their proposal has been placed on the reserve list.

²⁴ This also applies to Principal Investigators of a Synergy Grant Group.

²⁵ A new ERC main grant project may only start once the duration of the previous project (as stated in the Grant Agreement) has come to an end.

²⁶ As defined in the Grant Agreement.

²⁷ The duration of the ongoing project may, exceptionally, be extended, without affecting the eligibility of the proposal, for properly documented circumstances constituting force majeure or other unforeseen events or circumstances, which: a) have presented themselves after the call deadline and thus could not be anticipated at the time of the call deadline, b) the extension is essential for the proper completion of the ongoing project, and c) the ongoing project will end within three years of the call deadline. This and any other extension is subject to the agreement of the Granting Authority.

²⁸ The members of the ERC panels alternate to allow panel members to apply to the ERC calls in alternate years.

Call to which the PI applied under previous ERC WPs and proposal evaluation outcome		2027 Calls to which a PI is <u>NOT</u> eligible
2025 Starting, Consolidator, Advanced Grant, or Synergy Grant	Rejected on the grounds of a breach of research integrity ²⁹	STG, COG, ADG, Plus and SYG
2026 Starting, Consolidator, Advanced, ERC Plus or Synergy	Rejected on the grounds of a breach of research integrity ³⁰	STG, COG, ADG, Plus and SYG
2025 Starting, Consolidator, or Advanced Grant	C at Step 1	STG, COG, ADG, Plus and SYG
2026 Starting or Consolidator Grant	A or B at Step 2	No restrictions
	A not invited at Step 1	No restrictions
	B or C at Step 1	STG, COG, ADG, Plus and SYG
2026 Advanced Grant	A or B at Step 2	No restrictions
	A not invited at Step 1	No restrictions
	B or C at Step 1	STG, COG, ADG, Plus
2025 Synergy Grant	C at Step 1	SYG
2026 Synergy Grant	B or C at Step 1	SYG
2026 Plus Grant	Not retained at Step 1	Plus

The year of an ERC call refers to the ERC WP under which the call was published and can be established by its call identifier. A 2027 ERC call is therefore one that was published under the ERC WP 2027 and will have 2027 in the call identifier (for example ERC-2027-STG).

1.3 EVALUATION PROCESS

The ERC's peer review evaluation process has been carefully designed to identify scientific excellence irrespective of gender, age, nationality or institution of the Principal Investigator and other potential biases, and to take career breaks as well as diverse research career paths into account³⁰. The evaluations are monitored to guarantee transparency, fairness and impartiality in the treatment of proposals. ERC calls are expected to be highly competitive.

A single submission of the full proposal is followed by a two-step evaluation.

²⁹ This restriction will be implemented with due respect for the principle of proportionality.

³⁰ During the evaluation, the peer review panels will take into account the phase of the Principal Investigator's transition to independence, diverse research career paths and particularly noteworthy contributions to the research community, as well as possible breaks in the research career of the applicant and the effects of major life events or pandemic restrictions on the applicant's progression as a researcher.

ERC evaluation panels

The peer review evaluation is handled by 28 peer review evaluation panels (ERC panels), covering all fields of science, engineering and scholarship (see panel details and ERC keywords in [Annex 4.1](#)). For operational reasons, they are subdivided into three main research domains:

- Physical Sciences and Engineering (11 Panels)
- Life Sciences (9 Panels)
- Social Sciences and Humanities (8 Panels)

Before the deadline of a call, the names of the 28 panel chairs are published on the ERC website. The names of the panel members will be published after the call deadline and before Step 1 evaluation on the ERC website, provided that their consent for this publication has been obtained.

No Contact allowed with Peer Reviewers

Please note that, in accordance with the [ERC Rules of Submission and Evaluation under Horizon Europe](#), any direct or indirect contact about the peer review evaluation of an ERC call between an applicant legal entity or a PI submitting a proposal on behalf of an applicant legal entity, and any independent external expert³¹ involved in the peer review evaluation under the same call, is strictly forbidden. If such contact attempts to influence the evaluation process, it will be considered as a breach of research integrity and may result in the rejection of the proposal from the call (see section 3.11 of the ERC Rules of Submission and Evaluation). It can also constitute an exclusion situation under Article 138(1) of the Financial Regulation.

In addition, any contact with Peer Reviewers to obtain confidential information on the evaluation process is prohibited. ERC Peer Reviewers are bound to confidentiality during the evaluation and afterwards. Hence, they are not allowed to communicate about the evaluation and/or specific proposal(s) with the Principal Investigators or potential team members or persons linked to them, even after the completion of the evaluation process.

Panel allocation and panel budgets

It is the applicant's responsibility to choose and indicate the most relevant ERC panel ('primary evaluation panel') for the evaluation of the proposed research and to indicate one or more ERC keywords representing the research fields involved. The Principal Investigator may indicate a secondary evaluation panel.

When choosing the panel, please take careful note of the panel details and ERC keywords in [Annex 4.1](#).

The initial allocation of the proposal to a panel will be based on the preference expressed by the applicant. However, when necessary due to the expertise required for the evaluation, a proposal may be reallocated to a different panel with the agreement of both panel chairs concerned. In such cases, applicants are informed of the reallocation of the proposal at the latest through the notification for the invitation to the interview (if applicable) or in the Evaluation Report attached to the information letter with the final outcome of the evaluation of their respective proposal.

³¹ An independent external expert is an expert who is external to the ERC and the Commission and is working impartially in a personal capacity and without conflict of interest. Exceptionally, in duly justified cases, when relevant specialised knowledge is held by staff of Union institutions or bodies, and provided that these are not implementing Horizon Europe as a funding body, such staff may work as independent external experts in compliance with Article 29(1) of the Horizon Europe Regulation.

The composition of the ERC evaluation panels is by nature multi-disciplinary. The panel will determine if additional reviews by appropriate members of other panel(s) or additional remote experts are needed to evaluate the proposal.

An indicative budget is allocated to each panel in proportion to the budgetary demand of its assigned proposals. **This important principle ensures comparable success rates between the individual panels regardless of how many proposals each panel evaluates.** Based on the outcome of the evaluation at Step 1, up to 44 proposals per panel will be retained for Step 2 of the evaluation. Only proposals ranked **A invited** at Step 1 will be further evaluated at Step 2. Following the Step 2 evaluation, only proposals ranked **A** will be invited for grant preparation in priority order based on their rank in the consolidated call rank list and until the call budget is spent. The remaining proposals recommended for funding may be funded by the ERC if additional funds become available.

Evaluation process and important dates

An indicative evaluation timeline is available for the [Starting Grant](#) and [Consolidator Grant](#) Calls on the ERC website.



At both evaluation steps, every proposal will be evaluated for each of the two main elements of the proposal: the Research Project and the Principal Investigator. The panels will primarily evaluate the ground-breaking nature and ambition of the research project. At the same time, the panels will evaluate the intellectual capacity and creativity of the Principal Investigator, with a focus on the extent to which the Principal Investigator has the required scientific expertise and capacity to successfully execute the project.

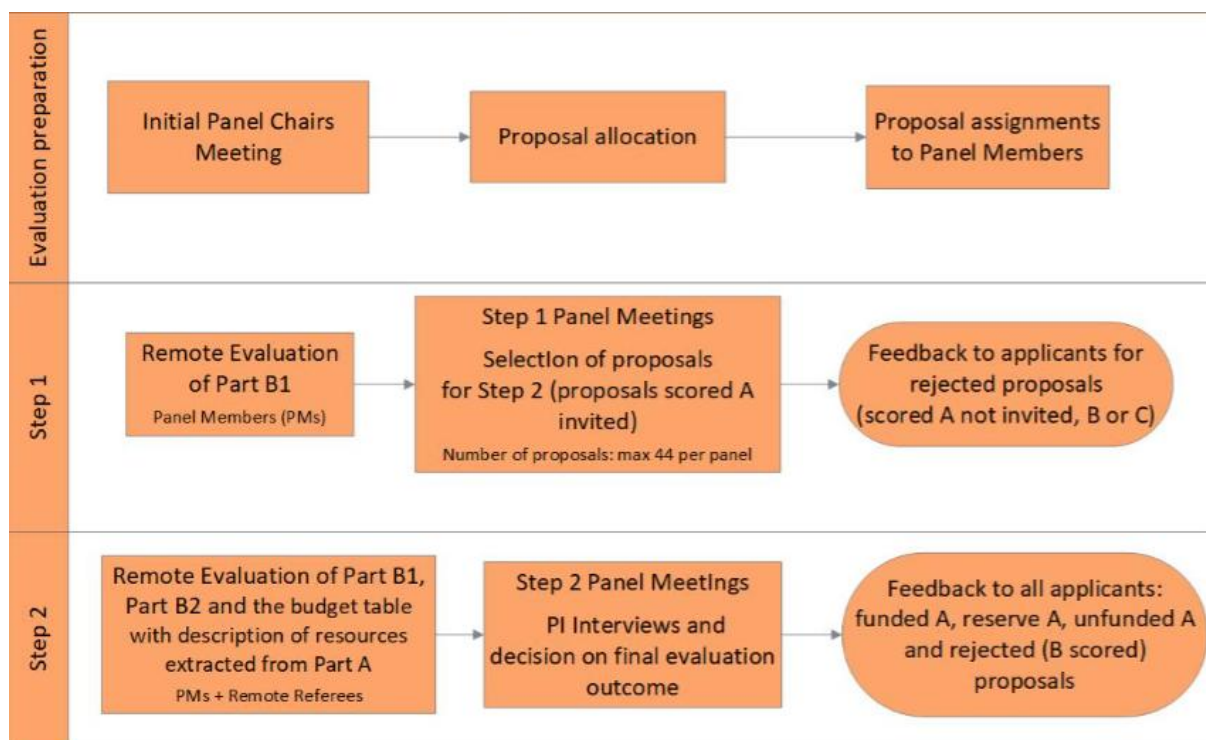
During the evaluation, the peer review panels shall take into account the phase of the Principal Investigator's transition to independence, as well as the information included in their CV and Track Record.

The ERC independent external experts deliver individual reviews in a remote evaluation phase at both Step 1 and Step 2. The ERC panels assess and score the proposals based on the individual reviews they have received, and on the panels' overall appreciation of their strengths and weaknesses.

A panel may decide that at Step 1 proposals with low scores in all individual reviews will not be discussed. In such cases, the threshold below which the proposals would not be discussed will be decided independently by the panel in question.

Resubmitted proposals in a subsequent ERC call will be evaluated as new proposals without any reference or comparison to the previous score and/or with previous assessments. The score received by a proposal submitted in a previous ERC call will neither be considered in the current evaluation nor affect its outcome, as the two evaluations are independent from each other and the competition each year is different. In addition, the content of the reviews from an ERC call will not be made available to reviewers of the resubmitted proposal.

ERC STG and ERC COG call evaluation procedure



STEP 1

At Step 1, Part I of the Scientific Proposal together with the Principal Investigator's CV and Track Record will be evaluated (see [Section 2.3](#)). After the remote evaluation phase, each panel meets to discuss all proposals assigned to the panel. Proposals will proceed to Step 2 based on the outcome of the Step 1 evaluation: up to 44 proposals per panel will be retained for Step 2 of the evaluation. At the end of Step 1 of the evaluation, the proposal will receive one of the following scores:

A invited - is of excellent quality and ranked sufficiently high to pass to Step 2 of the evaluation;

A not invited - is of excellent quality but not ranked sufficiently high³² to pass to Step 2 of the evaluation;

B - is of high quality but not sufficient to pass to Step 2 of the evaluation³³;

C - is not of sufficient quality to pass to Step 2 of the evaluation³³.

The Step 1 evaluation outcome is provided to the applicants receiving an **A not invited**, a **B** or a **C** score through an information letter together with an evaluation report. It includes the final panel score and ranking range of their proposal, the panel comment explaining the panel decision as well as the individual comments given by each reviewer³⁴. An applicant whose proposal is not of sufficient quality to pass to Step 2 of the evaluation and receives a score B or C for Starting Grant and a score C for Consolidator Grant will receive an Evaluation Report with a standardised panel comment and individual comments.

This communication is uploaded to the F&T Portal accounts of the Principal Investigator and host institution contacts (see [Section 3.2](#)). Applicants who receive an **A invited** score are invited for an

³² It exceeds the maximum threshold of proposals that can be passed to Step 2.

³³ The applicants may be subject to restrictions on submitting proposals to future ERC calls based on the outcome of the evaluation. Applicants will need to check the restrictions in place for each call.

³⁴ The pre-defined responses related to the questions regarding the Principal Investigator can be the following: Exceptional/Excellent/Very Good/Good/Non-competitive

interview to present their project at the Step 2 panel meeting. Each panel decides on the exact format of its interviews (number of slides allowed – if applicable, duration, time allocated to the presentation, and to the questions and answer session), which will be communicated to the applicants after Step 1. Applicants who pass to Step 2 do not receive a Step 1 evaluation report.

STEP 2

At Step 2, the complete Research Proposal (CV and Track Record, Part I and Part II of the Scientific Proposal, and Budget and Resources, present in the submission form) will be evaluated. After a remote evaluation phase, the panels meet again. Step 2 includes an interview of approximately 30 minutes of each applicant³⁵. During the Step 2 panel meeting, the applicants will be interviewed remotely, while the panel members will be present in the ERC premises. In exceptional and justified cases, if unable to attend a physical meeting in person, a panel member may participate in the panel meeting remotely by electronic means (videoconferencing or telephone-conferencing), subject to ERCEA's agreement.

The first part of the interview will be devoted to a presentation on the outline of the research project by the Principal Investigator. The remaining time will be devoted to a question-and-answer session. The PI may expect questions also related to the detailed budget table and resources, which is part of the application. The evaluation panels will review the requested budget for proposals recommended for funding and, if appropriate, recommend adjustments.

In view of the confidentiality of the evaluation process, applicants should not share the identity of panel members within their scientific communities until their names have been published on the ERC website.

The assessment by the panels will take into account the interview alongside the individual reviews. At the end of Step 2, following the timeline described above, applicants will be informed about the outcome of the evaluation. The score of their proposal can be either *A* or *B*:

- A** – the proposal fully meets the ERC's excellence criterion and is recommended for funding. Such project will be funded in priority order based on its rank if sufficient funds are available.
- B** – the proposal meets some but not all elements of the ERC's excellence criterion and will not be funded.

Evaluation outcome

The Step 2 evaluation outcome is provided to all applicants through an information letter together with an evaluation report. It includes the final panel score and ranking range of their proposal, the panel comment explaining the panel decision as well as the individual comments given by each reviewer. This communication is uploaded to the F&T Portal accounts of the PI and host institution contacts (see [Section 3.2](#)).

Panel comments

Comments by the individual reviewers may reflect divergent views. Differences of opinions about the proposal are part of scientific debate and are legitimate. Furthermore, the ERC panel may take a position that is different from what could be inferred from the individual reviews. A panel discussion could reveal an important weakness that was not identified by the individual reviewers. The panel comment reflects the final decision taken by the panel either by consensus decision or by majority vote based on the individual assessments and discussion in the panel.

Evaluation criterion and elements

³⁵ Should a planned interview not be possible due to exceptional circumstances beyond the control of the ERCEA, the panel will have to take its decision based on the written proposal.

"Excellence" is the sole criterion of evaluation.

The panels will primarily evaluate the ground-breaking nature and ambition of the research project. At the same time, the panels will evaluate the intellectual capacity and creativity of the Principal Investigator, with a focus on the extent to which the Principal Investigator has the required scientific expertise and capacity to successfully execute the project. The detailed evaluation elements applying to these two categories are set out below.

Research Project. The ground-breaking nature and ambition of the Research Project is assessed as follows:

At Step 1:

- To what extent does the research address important scientific questions?
- To what extent are the project's objectives ambitious, will the project advance the frontier of knowledge and is the proposed approach scientifically convincing?

At Step 2:

- To what extent does the research address important scientific questions?
- To what extent are the project's objectives ambitious, will the project advance the frontier of knowledge and is the proposed approach scientifically convincing?
- To what extent are the research methodology and working arrangements appropriate to achieve the goals of the project?
- To what extent are the timescales and resources adequate and properly justified?

Principal Investigator. The intellectual capacity and creativity of the Principal Investigator is assessed as follows:

At Step 1 and Step 2:

- To what extent has the PI demonstrated the ability to conduct groundbreaking research?
- To what extent does the PI provide evidence of creative and original thinking?
- To what extent does the PI have the required scientific expertise and capacity to successfully execute the project?

The use of artificial intelligence (AI) in grant proposal evaluation

The Scientific Council emphasises that use of external help in preparing a proposal from AI technologies or human third parties does not relieve the author from taking full authorship responsibilities. These responsibilities concern: acknowledgements, plagiarism and the practice of good scientific and professional conduct.

The Scientific Council emphasises that the use of external help, including generative AI systems, for the evaluation of research proposals is not permitted.

Information to Programme Committee and NCPs

After each peer review evaluation, a report is prepared by the ERCEA services and made available to the Programme Committee. The report provides information on the proposals received: it includes names of host institutions and personal data (i.e. names of applicant Principal Investigators),

evaluation scores of proposals, as well as panel comments and individual reviews. A subset of information is also made available to the National Contact Points. The NCP report provides names of host institutions and personal data (i.e. names of applicant Principal Investigators) and evaluation scores of proposals. Applicants have various rights as regards the processing of their personal data³⁶.

1.4 ETHICS AND SECURITY

Ethics

Every project funded or placed on a reserve list by the ERC under Horizon Europe is subject to an ethics review process. The ethics review process is independent from the scientific evaluation.

Please see Annex A to the [ERC Rules of Submission and Evaluation under Horizon Europe](#) for a detailed description of the ERC Ethics Review procedure.

The process is aimed at ensuring that all the research and innovation activities under Horizon Europe comply with ethics principles and relevant national, Union and international legislation, including the [Charter of Fundamental Rights of the European Union](#) and the [European Convention on Human Rights](#) and its Supplementary Protocols (in line with Article 19 of the Horizon Europe Regulation).

The main areas that are addressed during the ethics review process include:

1. Human embryonic stem cells and human embryos
2. Human participants
3. Human cells/tissues
4. Personal data
5. Animals
6. Non-EU countries
7. Environment, health and safety
8. Artificial Intelligence
9. Other ethics issues may be identified as new ethical issues, or issues not fully covered by the above questions.

The proposed research and innovation activities must have an exclusive focus on civil applications.

When submitting their proposal, applicants must complete the ethics issues table as part of the on-line proposal submission form. If applicable, they must also provide in the ethics self-assessment (in the same section of the form), concise details on how ethics issues will be addressed and upload any supporting documentation as separate annexes. Please see the [How to Complete your Ethics Self-Assessment](#) document for guidance. In order to determine whether your proposal contains [serious or complex ethics issues](#), please consult additional guidance documents available on the following link: [ERC Ethics Guidance for Project Management | European Research Council](#) Ethics guidance | ERC (europa.eu). In case the proposal involves the use of human embryonic stem cells, applicants may pay particular attention to the [Statement by the Commission on ethics/stem cells](#) that sets out a specific ethics framework.

It is important to provide a complete overview of all ethics issues during the submission phase in order to speed up the ethics review process (please also see [section 2.2](#) of this document for further details). For proposals that may raise serious or complex ethics issues, it is highly recommended to

³⁶ Applicants have the right to access their personal data, the right to rectify them, if necessary, and/or to restrict their processing or erase them. They are also entitled to object to the processing of their personal data, where applicable. If they would like to exercise their rights under the Regulation 2018/1725, if they have comments, questions or concerns, regarding the collection and use of their personal data, applicants are free to contact the ERCEA Controller at ERC-B2-CALL-COORDINATION@ec.europa.eu.

include a detailed ethics self-assessment. Additional information or documents may be requested from the applicants to finalise the ethics review. Applicants should be aware that no grant agreement will be signed by ERCEA prior to a satisfactory conclusion of the ethics review procedure.

Security

The Security Appraisal Procedure

The Security Appraisal Procedure is managed by the Directorate General for Migration and Home Affairs (DG HOME) of the European Commission.

It allows the ERCEA to detect and assess possible security risks and propose mitigation measures to support beneficiaries in ensuring compliance with applicable security rules, EU and National Law (in line with article 20 of the Horizon Europe regulation)³⁷.

It covers three main areas:

- The possible involvement of classified or security sensitive information³⁸.
- The possible involvement and development of materials, methods, technologies, knowledge or applications that could have, if misused, direct negative implications for the security of individuals, groups, or states³⁹.
- The possible applicability of national or third country security restrictions (such as technology restrictions, national security classification, etc.)

Applicants are requested to identify if the proposed activity will use and/or generate information which might raise security concerns. They must complete the security issues table as part of the online proposal submission form (Section 4), and provide, if applicable, supporting documentation as separate annex(es).

For proposals selected for funding, additional information regarding security issues may be requested at a later stage. For further information see [section 4.5](#) of this document Annex 4 to the [ERC Work Programme 2027](#).

³⁷ See: [how-to-handle-security-sensitive-projects_en.pdf](#)

³⁸ See: [classification-of-information-in-he-projects_he_en.pdf](#)

³⁹ See: [guidance-note-potential-misuse-of-research-results_he_en.pdf](#)

1.5 MEANS OF REDRESS, ENQUIRIES AND COMPLAINTS

Please see section 3.9 of the [ERC Rules of Submission and Evaluation under Horizon Europe](#) for a detailed description of the admissibility, eligibility and evaluation review procedures and enquiries and complaints.

Means of redress:

Upon reception of the information letter with the evaluation report or with the results of the admissibility or eligibility review, the Principal Investigator and/or the host institution (applicant legal entity) may request an admissibility, eligibility or evaluation review if there is an indication that the results of the admissibility or eligibility checks were incorrect or that there has been a procedural shortcoming or a manifest error of assessment in the evaluation of the proposal.

A request for evaluation review can be made if the Principal Investigator and/or the host institution consider that the applicable evaluation procedure has not been correctly applied to its proposal. The evaluation review procedure is not meant to call into question the scientific judgement made by the peer review panel. Complaints must focus on aspects concerning the evaluation of the proposals (e.g. admissibility or eligibility checks, evaluation procedure, etc), not their merits. Thus, applicants can raise procedural irregularities, factual errors, manifest errors of assessment or abuse of powers. Mere repetitions of the content of the proposal or disagreements with the result or reasoning of the technical evaluation will not be considered.

The information letter will provide information on the means of redress and how to introduce the request. The letter will specify a deadline for the receipt of any such requests, which will be 30 calendar days from the date of receiving the information letter⁴⁰. A formal notification is considered to have been accessed by the applicant 10 calendar days after sending, if not accessed before in the system⁴¹.

The request must be:

- related to the evaluation process, or admissibility/eligibility checks, for the call and grants in question;
- set out using the online form, including a clear description of the grounds for complaint (within the limit of 7000 characters);
- received within the time limit specified in the information letter;
- sent by the Principal Investigator and/or the host institution.

Requests that do not meet the above-mentioned conditions, or do not deal with the admissibility, eligibility or evaluation of a specific proposal, will not be admitted.

A redress committee may be convened to examine the request for the review of the admissibility, eligibility or evaluation process. The redress committee will bring together staff of the ERC Executive Agency with the requisite scientific, technical and legal expertise. The committee shall be chaired by and include staff of ERCEA who were not involved in the evaluation of the proposals. The committee's role is to ensure a coherent interpretation of the requests, based on all available information related to the proposals and their evaluation, and fair and equal treatment of all applicants.

In the case of evaluation review procedure, the committee itself, however, does not re-evaluate the proposal. Depending on the nature of the complaint, the committee may review the evaluation

⁴⁰ Applicants of proposals selected for funding will normally not receive information on the means of redress in their information letter but if the applicant considers that there are grounds for such request, they can redress.

⁴¹ Evaluation result letters are formal notifications. This means that deadlines triggered by these letters (evaluation review request, etc.) must be counted accordingly (i.e. access date + 1 day (event) + 30 days (deadline) OR sending date + 1 day (event) + 10 days (embargo period) + 30 days (deadline), if the letter was not accessed in the system).

report, the individual comments and examine the profile and expertise of the experts. The committee may also contact the panel chair/panel member(s) concerned. **The committee will not call into question the scientific judgement of appropriately qualified panels of experts.** In the light of its review, the committee will recommend a course of action to the Responsible Authorizing Officer (RAO) for the call. If there is clear evidence of a shortcoming that could have affected the eventual funding decision, it is possible that all or part of the proposal will be re-evaluated.

Please note that:

- a partial or a total re-evaluation will only be carried out if there is evidence of a shortcoming that affects the outcome of the evaluation;
- the committee may uphold the initial outcome if it concludes that the errors identified would not substantially have affected the outcome of the evaluation (for example, when the ranking of the proposal would not change);
- the evaluation score following any re-evaluation will be regarded as definitive. It may be lower than the original score;
- only one request at the time for evaluation review per proposal will be considered by the committee;
- all requests for evaluation review will be treated in confidence.

Other means of redress:

The above procedure does not prevent the applicants from resorting to other means of redress, such as:

- requesting a legal review of the Agency decision under Article 22 of Council Regulation 58/2003⁴² ('Article 22 request'), within 1 month of receiving the ERCEA's letter; or
- bringing an action for annulment under Article 263 of the TFEU⁴³ ('Article 263 action') against the Agency, within 2 months of receiving the ERCEA's letter.

Applicants may choose which means of redress they wish to pursue⁴⁴. Applicants are asked not to take more than one formal action at a time. Once the Agency/Commission communicates the final decision on an action, applicants can take a further action against that decision. Deadlines for further action will start to run from when applicants receive the final decision⁴⁵.

Other types of complaints on decisions affecting the involvement of applicants in the programme:

Any other complaint against a decision affecting the involvement of applicants in Horizon Europe shall be addressed to the Agency Director within 30 calendar days from the receipt of the communication of the Agency decision⁴⁶.

⁴² [Council Regulation \(EC\) No 58/2003 of 19 December 2002 laying down the statute for executive agencies to be entrusted with certain tasks in the management of Community programmes](#) (O J L 11, 16.01.2003, p.1).

⁴³ Treaty on the Functioning of the European Union (O J C 326, 26.10.2012, p. 47–390).

⁴⁴ Even though applicants may freely choose which means of redress to pursue, first submitting a request for evaluation review will ensure that the applicants' case can be heard on all the above-mentioned possible instances.

⁴⁵ Please be aware that, as per Article 22 of Regulation 58/2003, the Commission shall take a decision within a deadline of two months. Therefore, if you first file an Article 22 request you may not be able afterwards to submit an evaluation review request within 30 days from the date of receiving the information letter. Please note as well that applicants of proposals included in the reserve list may not file an Article 22 request because their information letter does NOT constitute a final position concerning funding. If the proposal is finally rejected, the rejection letter will list the available means of redress. To be noted that if you file an Article 22 request, a subsequent action for annulment may be brought before the Court of Justice against the Commission's decision on the Article 22 request and not against the Agency's decision.

⁴⁶ A formal notification that has not been accessed within 10 calendar days after sending is considered to have been accessed by the applicant.

1.6 QUESTIONS RELATED TO THE CALL

You can find useful information on the [ERC website](#) and more specifically on the pages dedicated to the Starting Grant Call and Consolidator Grant Call.

An extended set of Frequently Asked Questions for the ERC calls is available on the [EU Funding & Tenders Portal](#) on the relevant call page (ERC-2027-STG or ERC-2027-COG). They can be filtered by calls or categories and answer the most common questions on how to prepare and submit an ERC application.

For additional questions related to the call, please contact the relevant Call coordination team:
ERC-2027-STG-APPLICANTS@ec.europa.eu OR ERC-2027-COG-APPLICANTS@ec.europa.eu.

For questions related to the ethics issues of the proposal, please contact the Ethics Support team:
ERC-ETHICS-REVIEW@ec.europa.eu.

For questions on open access to scientific publications and research data management, please see the section on Open Science in the Horizon Europe Model Grant Agreement used for ERC actions or contact ERC-OPEN-ACCESS@ec.europa.eu.

2. COMPLETING AN APPLICATION

2.1 OVERVIEW OF AN ERC APPLICATION

An ERC application is composed of:

- the administrative form (Part A) including the detailed budget table, description of resources (Section 'Budget') and time commitment (Section 'Other questions');
- completed Part B1 template (composed of Part I of the Scientific Proposal, Curriculum Vitae and Track Record);
- completed Part B2 template (composed of Part II of the Scientific Proposal and funding ID table);
- mandatory documentation (PhD certificate, Host institution support letter, and, if relevant, any documentation needed to support a request for eligibility extension);
- if applicable, additional supporting documentation related to ethics and security issues.

2.2 THE ADMINISTRATIVE FORM

The online submission form is accessed via the call submission link in the F&T Portal. The electronic form has 7 sections, which need to be completed before a submission can take place. Many fields are mandatory and specific to the ERC calls, and we therefore advise you to create the draft proposal well in advance of the submission deadline. **All mandatory fields are marked in red if left empty. Failure to fill in any mandatory field will block submission (see [Annex 4.6](#)).**

'General Information: This section contains information about the research proposal, including the project acronym, title, duration and abstract. Furthermore, in this section you will select the ERC evaluation panel which you believe is best suited to evaluate the research proposal (for further details, see section [1.3 Evaluation process](#) of this guide). If the proposal covers several scientific disciplines, you may indicate a 'secondary review panel'. You may indicate up to four ERC keywords as listed in [Annex 4.1](#) that cover your proposal subject. The abstract should provide a clear understanding of the objectives of the research proposal and how they will be achieved. The abstract will be used as a short description of your research proposal in the evaluation process. Please note that in case your proposal is funded this abstract will be published. It must therefore be short and precise and should not contain confidential information.

Declarations: The section contains general declarations related to the proposal and participation in Horizon Europe⁴⁷. They have to be filled in by the Principal Investigator on behalf of the host institution and "We" has to be understood as both "the Principal Investigator" and "the host institution".

Participants: This section contains information about the Principal Investigator, the host institution and additional beneficiaries where relevant⁴⁸. One section will appear for each beneficiary. The section contains non-editable data from the Participant Register, such as name, address and

⁴⁷ Please note that the ERCEA may at any time during the evaluation process request the applicants to provide the written consents mentioned in the declarations. These consents should not be submitted with the application, but the applicant must ensure the written consent from all participants prior to the call submission deadline.

⁴⁸ Where they bring scientific added value to the project, additional team members may also be hosted by additional legal entities, which may be established anywhere, including outside the European Union or Associated Countries, or international organisations, subject to any restrictions provided in Annex 3 to the ERC Work Programme 2027.

organisation type. It also shows whether the beneficiary has a gender equality plan (GEP) ⁴⁹. The GEP or equivalent must fulfil the mandatory requirements listed in Annex 5 of the [ERC WP 2027](#) and will be necessary before the signature of the grant agreement. The name and e-mail of contact persons - including the Principal Investigator and host institution contact- are **read-only**, from the information introduced when the proposal is created. Further details such as ORCID number, researcher ID, other ID, last name at birth, gender, nationality etc., should be filled for the Principal Investigator as well as the address and telephone number of each contact person. The Principal Investigator mobile number is an essential information for the Step 2 interview logistics.

This section contains also the following fields:

- Departments carrying out the proposed work: the data field “Links with other proposal participating organisations” is optional and only to be filled if there are dependencies with other participating host institutions (for example, team members from another host institution). This field should not be filled for mono-beneficiary grants.
- Person in charge of the proposal (Principal Investigator): on this page, there is a field on the ‘career stage’ of the Principal Investigator. This information will not be provided to the evaluators and it will not be evaluated. The field on the career stages refers to the ones defined in Frascati 2015 manual (see below). Please choose the appropriate option.

Category A – Top grade researcher: the single highest grade/post at which research is normally conducted. Example: ‘full professor’ or ‘director of research’.

Category B – Senior researcher: Researchers working in positions not as senior as top position but more senior than newly qualified doctoral graduates (IsCED level 8). Examples: ‘associate professor’, or ‘senior researcher’ or ‘principal investigator’.

Category C – Recognised researcher: the first grade/post into which a newly qualified doctoral graduate would normally be recruited. Examples: ‘assistant professor’, ‘investigator’ or ‘post-doctoral fellow’.

Category D – First stage researcher: Either doctoral students at the IsCED level 8 who are engaged as researchers, or researchers working in posts that do not normally require a doctorate degree. Examples: ‘PhD students’ or ‘junior researchers’ (without a PhD).

Budget: This section contains the proposal budget including the total eligible project costs and the requested EU contribution for the project. In case the project has multiple partners, each partner will

⁴⁹ To be eligible, legal entities from Member States and Associated Countries that are public bodies, research organisations or higher education establishments (including private research organisations and private higher education establishments) applying as beneficiaries or affiliated entities must have at the moment of grant signature and during the duration of the grant a gender equality plan, covering the following minimum process-related requirements:

- Publication: a formal document published on the institution’s website and signed and/or adopted by the top management.
- Dedicated resources: commitment of resources and expertise in gender equality to implement the plan.
- Data collection and monitoring: sex/gender disaggregated data on personnel (and students for the establishments concerned) and reporting at least every two years based on indicators.
- Training: awareness-raising/training for staff and decision-makers on gender equality, for instance on unconscious gender biases.

Content-wise, it is recommended that the gender equality plan addresses the following areas, using concrete measures and targets:

- work-life balance and organisational culture.
- gender balance in leadership and decision-making.
- gender equality in recruitment and career progression.
- integration of the gender dimension into research and teaching content.
- measures against gender-based violence including sexual harassment.

A self-declaration will be requested in the [Participant Register](#). If all the above-mentioned mandatory requirements are met through. Another strategic document, such as a development plan or an inclusion or a diversity strategy, it can be considered as an equivalent. This eligibility criterion does not apply to other categories of legal entities, such as private for-profit organisations, including SMEs, non-governmental or civil society organisations.

have a separate budget section to be filled. The costs are given in whole Euros (**not kilo Euro or percentages**). A description and justification of the resources should be provided in the text box (Resources) under the budget table. **The budget table and description of resources will be made available to the experts evaluating the proposal. The Resources section has a maximum length of 8000 characters (including spaces). Please note that all information related to the budget needs to appear in the budget table and no additional information (e.g. in an annex) will be accepted. Please refer to [Section 2.3](#) for further instruction on how to draw up the budget.**

Ethics:

The ethics issues table serves to identify any ethical aspects of the proposed work. This table has to be completed even if there are no issues (simply confirm that none of the ethical issues applies to the proposal). In case you answer YES to any of the questions, you are requested to provide an ethics self-assessment (and available supporting documentation as annexes), as detailed in the '[How to Complete your Ethics Self-Assessment](#) guidance'. Please refer to [section 1.4](#) for further details.

The page numbers required for the Ethics table questions in PART A should be page numbers of the proposal (part B2). You are welcome to add Ethics Technical Annexes as supplementary documents but those will not be assessed during the scientific evaluation of the proposal. The ethics review process is independent from the evaluation procedure and it is assessed if the proposal is recommended for funding by the evaluation panels.

Security:

The security issues table serves to identify if the proposed activity will use and/or generate information which might raise security concerns. The table provided must be completed by answering YES or NO to all questions. Where necessary and applicable, you are requested to provide available documentation as separate annexes. For proposals selected for funding, additional information regarding security issues may be requested at a later stage.

Other questions:

This section pertains to the date of the PhD defence of the Principal Investigator and their academic training, to extension requests as well as to declarations related to eligibility and expected working time in EU or in an AC. Here, you are also asked to specify your commitment in terms of percentage of working time you are willing to devote to the proposed project. You are expected to spend a minimum of 50% for STG and 40% for COG of your working time on the ERC project, and a minimum of 50% of your working time in an EU MS or an AC. The personnel cost for the Principal Investigator provided in section "Budget" cannot be higher than the percentage indicated here. This information will be provided to the experts at Step 2 together with the section "Budget" (see [Annex 4.7](#)). This section also contains permission statements on sharing evaluation data. These data-related consents are entirely voluntary. In addition, this section contains a specific declaration as regards the consent obtained from participants and researchers. **The Principal Investigator will have to declare that they have the written consent of all participants on their involvement and the content of their proposal, as well as of any researcher mentioned in the proposal on their participation in the project** (either as team member, collaborator, other Principal Investigator or member of the advisory board). Please note that the ERCEA may request the applicant Principal Investigator at any time during the evaluation, to provide proof of the written consent obtained prior to the call submission deadline.

As established in section 3.3 of the [ERC Rules of Submission and Evaluation under Horizon Europe](#), Principal Investigators may identify up to three reviewers to be excluded from the evaluation of their proposal and indicate their details in this section. Applicants must complete all the required information in relation to the reviewer concerned (first and last name, institution, town, country, webpage) in the electronic submission form (Form A, section "Other questions") for their request to be considered. This information must be complete and correct, otherwise the request for the reviewer's exclusion may not be considered.

2.3 THE RESEARCH PROPOSAL

The “research proposal” consists of Part I of the Scientific Proposal, Curriculum Vitae and Track Record (Part B1 of the application form), Part II of the Scientific Proposal (Part B2 of the application form) and Resources and Time Commitment (Part A of the application form, i.e. budget and resources from section ‘Budget’ and time commitment from section ‘Other questions’). **The templates of Part B1 and Part B2 that are provided in the submission system (zip-file) should be used.** Each proposal page shall carry a **header** presenting the Principal Investigator's **last name**, the **acronym of the proposal**, and the reference to the respective proposal section (**Part B1** or **Part B2**).

The following parameters **must** be respected for the layout:

Page Format	Font Type	Font Size	Line Spacing	Margins
A4	Times New Roman Arial or similar	At least 11	Single	2 cm side 1.5 bottom

In fairness to all applicants, the **page limits will be strictly applied**. References and the Funding ID section are not counted towards these page limits. Only the material that is presented within these limits will be evaluated. Peer reviewers will be asked to read the material presented within the page limits only (provided that the instructions regarding font type and size are respected) and will not be under any obligation either to read beyond them, or to read any information provided by the links to webpages⁵⁰.

Be aware that at **Step 1** only Part I of the Scientific Proposal and the Curriculum Vitae and Track Record, are evaluated by the panel members (they have no access to other parts and sections) and remote evaluators (see below).

At **Step 2**, the complete proposal which also includes Part II of the Scientific Proposal, Resources and Time Commitment are evaluated by panel members and remote reviewers.

Part I of the Scientific Proposal is the part that will be seen by the evaluation panel in the first step of the evaluation, and that forms the basis for the panel’s decision whether they want to assess your project and interview you in the second step of the evaluation. Therefore, when drafting, pay particular attention to Part I of the Scientific Proposal and do not think of it as simply complementing Part II of the Scientific Proposal. It is important that Part I of the Scientific Proposal contains all essential information.

During the Step 1 evaluation, the panel members' expertise covers a wide range of proposals within a research field. The panel members are asked to act as generalists when evaluating the proposals. The panel to which a proposal is allocated may request additional reviews from remote evaluators. Remote evaluators at Step 1 can be either members of other panels than the panel to which the proposal is assigned, or remote Step 1 experts. Further expertise on each proposal retained to Step 2 is brought to the evaluation by Remote Reviewers. Remote Reviewers are scientists and scholars who do not participate in the panel meetings and who deliver their individual reviews before the Step 2 panel meeting.

Part B1 of the application form

The Part B1 cover page should list the name of the Principal Investigator and the host institution, the title, acronym and abstract of the proposal as well as the project duration (in months). The abstract should be half a page and must be a copy/paste of the abstract from the submission form (section

⁵⁰ An application can be submitted in any official language of the EU. The working language of the ERC evaluation panels is English. Therefore, the evaluation reports will be available in English only. If the proposal is not in English, the ERCEA will provide the evaluation panels with a raw machine translation version of the proposal. Such a translated version will not be verified by the ERCEA. An English translation of the abstract must be included in the proposal.

'General Information'). For inter-disciplinary/cross-panel proposals, please indicate the additional ERC review panel(s) and explain why the proposal needs to be considered by more than one panel.

Part I of the Scientific Proposal (max. 5 pages, excluding cover page and references) should present the envisaged research and it should: (1) lay out the current state of knowledge, (2) explain the scientific question and the objectives of the project and (3) present the overall approach or research strategy to reach the project goals. It should convince the evaluation panel that the proposal presents an original and creative idea addressing an important question in the research field(s). It should explain how the project will advance the frontier of knowledge, and what contribution it will make to the research field(s) i.e. what may be changed, opened, challenged or how the results of the work will alter the current understanding of the field. Furthermore, the overall scientific approach or research strategy as laid out in the proposal should be scientifically convincing.

Applicants should keep in mind the evaluation elements when drafting the proposal (please see section 1.6.5 in the Work Programme).

Only those who have presented a convincing proposal at Step 1 will advance to the next stage of the evaluation.

References should be included (they do not count towards the page limits).

Curriculum Vitae and Track Record are presented in one single template of up to four pages. The applicant is expected to include their personal details, education, key qualifications, current and previous positions. It should also include the names of their PhD supervisor(s) and postdoctoral mentor(s), a list of up to ten research outputs that demonstrate how the applicant has advanced knowledge in their field with an emphasis on more recent achievements and a list of selected examples of significant peer recognition. A short explanation of the significance of the selected outputs, the role of the applicant in producing each of them, and how they demonstrate the applicant's capacity to successfully carry out their proposed project, as well as a short explanation of the importance of the listed examples of significant peer recognition may be included. For examples of significant peer recognition, the applicant should explain the importance of the award or recognition.

The applicant may also include relevant additional information on career breaks, diverse career paths, and life events, as well as any particularly noteworthy contributions to the research community. These will provide context to the evaluation panels when assessing the Principal Investigator's research achievements and peer recognition in relation to their career stage.

Applicants are expected to report their publications, patents and any other research outputs correctly, including all authors in the same order as published. Joint authorships (e.g. co-first author, multiple corresponding author) must also be properly indicated.

Part B2 of the application form

Part II of the Scientific Proposal (max 7 pages): This should be a detailed explanation of the project implementation, including research methodology, work plan, risk assessment, and mitigating measures and any further necessary background not included in Part I of the Scientific Proposal. While applicants are free to provide an explanation for the resources and the budget in this section, a detailed and exhaustive budget breakdown, justifying the resources requested, must be provided in the section specifically dedicated to Resources and Time Commitment (Part A, Section 'Budget'). In other words, Part II of the Scientific Proposal cannot deviate from the Resources section when describing the methodology, workplan etc. Applicants should keep in mind the evaluation criterion and elements when drafting their Scientific Proposal (see [Section 1.3](#) – Evaluation Process).

The length of "Part II of the Scientific Proposal" is strictly limited to 7 pages. References should be included (they do not count towards the page limits).

The panel and the external reviewers will review Parts I and II together for the Step 2 evaluation. Therefore, Part II should not be a repetition of Part I.

Funding ID: a succinct "Funding ID" should be included and must specify any current research grants and their subject, and any on-going application for work related to the proposal. **The Funding ID section does not count towards the page limits.**

Budget and description of resources (included in the online submission form)

PLEASE NOTE: The Budget Table and description of resources are part of the online submission form (part A, Section 'Budget').

The Resources text box (under the budget table) should provide a clear description and justification of the proposal budget and, if applicable, of the additional funding. If additional funding is requested, the costs must be indicated in the budget table in the appropriate cost category.

With the exception of clear mistakes (detected cases of obvious clerical errors⁵¹), in case of inconsistency between the budget table and the description of resources, the figures entered in the budget table will prevail.

Budget overview table

The ERC funds up to 100% of the total eligible costs. The costs cover the full project duration¹². This includes the direct costs of the project plus a flat-rate financing of indirect costs calculated as 25% of the total eligible direct costs excluding the direct eligible costs for subcontracting and internally invoiced goods and services, which already include indirect costs. The flat rate is automatically calculated by the system. Only Euro integers should be used when preparing the budget table.

The budget is subdivided in different cost categories:

- A. **Direct personnel costs** (Principal Investigator, senior staff, post docs, students, other personnel costs).
- B. **Subcontracting costs** (no indirect costs).
- C. **Purchase costs** [travel and subsistence, equipment (including major equipment), consumables (including fieldwork and animal costs), publications (including any costs related to Open Access fees) and dissemination, and other additional direct costs].
- D. **Internally invoiced goods and services** (no indirect costs).
- E. **Indirect costs.**

If additional funding⁵² above the ceiling of 1.500.000 € for STG and 2.000.000 € for COG is requested to cover further eligible costs, then it needs to be fully justified in the description of resources.

Additional funding is intended to cover further eligible costs for any cost category when these are necessary to carry out the proposed work.

Additional funding request may also be subject to 25% overhead, depending on the cost category (as for costs budgeted within the standard STG/COG ceiling). The 25% flat-rate does not apply to costs related to subcontracting or internally invoiced goods and services.

⁵¹ See Articles 154 and 203 (3) of the Financial Regulation and section 2.3 of the [ERC Rules of Submission and Evaluation under Horizon Europe](#).

⁵² Additional funding costs of ERC frontier research grants are a separate cost category in the Model Grant Agreement used for ERC actions. These costs will be eligible if they fulfil the eligibility conditions set out in the Model Grant Agreement for this cost category, if they are incurred for the activities and objectives for which the additional funding may be awarded, and if they are in line with the specific eligibility conditions for the other relevant cost categories as set out in the Model Grant Agreement.

Additional funding is meant to cover costs that would exceed the normal grant maximum. Any cost requested under additional funding must be necessary for the implementation of the proposed research activities.

Please note that for costs that can be incurred by applicants relocating to the EU or an AC as a consequence of receiving an ERC grant, the cost of the Principal Investigator's one-way ticket to EU or AC country may be requested, only if in line with the normal practice and the accounting policy of the host institution, and within the duration of the project; other personal costs (e.g. tickets of family members and all relocation costs related to them) incurred because of moving to the EU or AC cannot be claimed on the grant.

Purchases of equipment, infrastructure, or other assets used for the action must be declared as depreciation costs. Moreover, an applicant can request to include in the Grant Agreement equipment, infrastructure or other assets purchased specifically for the action (or developed as part of the action tasks) that may exceptionally be declared as full capitalised costs⁵³. These items should be clearly listed and justified in the proposal.

In case the 'total eligible costs' differ from the 'requested EU contribution', specify in the Resources section what exactly is funded from other sources. Please carefully check all values of the budget table. Use only Euro integers when preparing the budget table. **Please note that while the 'total eligible costs' in the budget table are calculated automatically based on the figures inserted in the individual columns, the 'requested EU contribution' has to be filled manually. Please make sure to update the 'Requested EU contribution' if updates are made in any of the cost categories.**

Care costs directly linked to implementing the ERC project are eligible under ERC rules, if they are consistent with the rules of the host institution. These are exceptional or additional costs that grantees may incur while implementing their ERC project because they need to be absent from their care responsibilities to meet the project objectives (e.g. childcare). Examples of such absences include fieldwork, conferences, visits to large facilities (for example laboratories or research ships).

For more information on eligible- and ineligible direct and indirect costs as well as the different cost categories, applicants should consult the [Model Grant Agreement used for ERC actions](#).

The Principal Investigator will have the flexibility to modify the budgetary breakdown during the course of the project. Requests to modify the budgetary breakdown of additional funding may be accepted only provided that such modifications remain within the objectives for which the additional funding was awarded.

Section C. Resources (text box below the budget table)

To facilitate the assessment of resources by the panels:

1. Describe all the cost categories considered necessary for the project. The project cost estimation should be as accurate as possible. The requested budget should be fully justified and in proportion to the actual needs. The evaluation panels assess the estimated costs carefully; **unjustified budgets will be reduced**.
2. Describe the size and nature of the team, indicating, where appropriate, the key team members and their roles. In case one or more team members are engaged by another host institution, their participation has to be fully justified with respect to the scientific added value they bring to the project and in relation to the additional cost this may impose. When estimating your personnel costs take into account the working time dedicated to the project.

⁵³ Where needed for the viability of the action (including its financial viability) and recorded under a fixed asset account of the beneficiary in compliance with international accounting standards and the beneficiary's usual cost accounting practices.

- 3.** Explain and describe in detail any additional funding requested for the project, indicating the budget items for which you are requesting the additional funding for (the requested additional funding must be included in the budget table).
- 4.** Include a short technical description of any requested equipment, why you need it and how much you plan to use it for the project.
- 5.** Include a realistic estimation of the costs for Open Access to project outputs. Costs for providing immediate Open Access to publications are eligible if the publishing venue is fully open access (i.e. a fully open access journal, book or publishing platforms) and if they are incurred during the lifetime of the project. This concerns article processing charges, book processing charges and other publishing fees such as page charges or colour charges.
- 6.** Describe any existing resources not requiring EU funding that will be used for the project, such as infrastructure and equipment.
- 7.** If applicable, specify the cost items covered by your 'Other personnel costs' category (e.g. technician, etc.) and the cost items covered by your 'Other additional direct costs' category (e.g. certificate on the financial statement).

The information entered in the section 'Budget' (including "Resources") of the administrative form (Part A) together with the time commitment in section 'Other questions' will be provided to the independent external experts in the form of Proposal Budget Report for their assessment. An example of Proposal Budget Report is shown in [Annex 4.7](#). It shows how experts will see the information entered in the section 'Budget' (including "Resources") and the time commitment in section 'Other questions' of the administrative form (Part A).

2.4 SUPPORTING DOCUMENTATION

A scanned copy of the following supporting documentation needs to be submitted with the proposal by uploading them electronically in PDF format:

1. **PhD certificate.** You must submit scanned copies of documents proving your eligibility for the grant, i.e. the PhD certificate (or equivalent doctoral degree, see [Annex 4.3](#) to this document) **clearly indicating** the date of the successful defence of PhD.

If:

- the PhD certificate does not explicitly state the date of the successful defence of PhD, the applicant should provide a written confirmation from the awarding institution stating the said date;
- the PhD defence was not successful or following the PhD defence, corrections were required, the applicant should provide an official document indicating that the defence was not successful and a date when the corrections to the PhD thesis were approved;
- no defence was organised in the awarding institution, the applicant should provide a written confirmation from the awarding institution stating that no defence was organised and indicating the date when the PhD was approved.

[Annex 4.9](#) provides a template which can be filled in by the PhD awarding institution.

If you request an **extension of the eligibility window** (beyond 10 years after PhD for STG applicants and beyond 15 years after PhD for COG applicants), the relevant documented evidence must be provided as a single PDF document. Please indicate, on a cover page, the duration of the requested extension together with an explanation of how the extension has been calculated. To further clarify your calculation, supporting documents should be added to this cover page. The cover page with all supporting documentation should be uploaded as one single PDF under “Annex 1 – Extension Request”.

[Annex 4.4](#) provides further details and [Annex 4.8](#) provides a template for the “Eligibility extension” cover page.

2. **Host institution support letter** - As the applicant's legal entity, the host institution must confirm its support to the project and to the Principal Investigator. As part of the application, the host institution must provide a binding statement that the conditions of independence are already fulfilled or will be provided to the Principal Investigator if the application is successful. The template letter is part of the zip-file available in the submission system (see [Annex 4.2](#)). The complete wording should be transcribed with the official letterhead of the HI, signed with a legally binding signature according to the practices of the institution (e.g. blue-ink, digital), stamped and dated by the institution's legal representative. In case it is digitally signed⁵⁴, there is no need to stamp it. A PDF version must be uploaded in the submission system. **Proposals that do not include this institutional statement may be declared inadmissible.**
3. Documents related to the **ethics** issues (i.e. supporting documentation). Where necessary, the applicant(s) shall provide any available documentation, such as: (a) favourable opinion(s) of relevant ethics committee(s); (b) regulatory approval(s) or authorisation(s) of the competent national or local authority(ies) in the country(ies) in which the research is to be carried out; (c) templates of information sheets and informed consent forms, etc. The supporting documentation must be provided to the ERCEA at the latest during the ethics review. If such documentation is available and provided with the application at submission stage, it may help speed up the ethics review process following evaluation. **Please note that**

⁵⁴ If the letter is digitally signed, please do not lock it.

the ethics self-assessment is included in section 'Ethics' of the online proposal submission form.

- 4.** Documents related to the **security** issues (i.e. supporting documentation). Where necessary, the applicant(s) shall provide available documentation at submission stage. For proposals selected for funding, additional information regarding security issues may be requested at a later stage. **Please note that the security self-assessment is included in section 'Security' of the online proposal submission form.**

Copies of official documents can be submitted in any of the EU official languages. **Document(s) in any other language must be provided together with a certified translation into English or into any other official EU language.**

Please provide only the documents requested above. Unless specified in the call, any hyperlinks to other documents, embedded material, and any other documents (company brochures, support letters, reports, audio, video, multimedia, etc.) will be disregarded. **Experts will not have access to any supporting documentation during the evaluation.**

All annexes, including the PhD documentation, the host institution support letter (and where relevant, documentation related to ethics and security issues or documentation for requesting an eligibility extension) should be provided and uploaded as separate PDF documents. They do not count towards the maximum page limits for the proposal.

3. SUBMITTING AN APPLICATION

3.1 IMPORTANT INFORMATION

- Regularly consult the [F&T](#) Portal call page for updated information on the calls.
- Make sure that the personal information added in the Submission Form is accurate as this information is used to personalise the communications to applicants and the Evaluation Reports.
- In case of technical problems with the submission system, please contact EC-FUNDING-TENDER-SERVICE-DESK@ec.europa.eu or get in touch with the **helpdesk** directly on **+32 (2) 29 92222** to receive immediate assistance.
- Registration and submission via the F&T Portal submission system should be done as early as possible and well in advance of the call deadline. **Applicants, who wait until shortly before the close of the call to start uploading their proposal, take a serious risk that the uploading will not be concluded in time and thus the 'SUBMIT' button will not be active anymore in order to conclude the submission process.**
- Only the person creating the draft proposal will have the right to manage the access rights of other people to the proposal and will be able to modify any parts of the proposal and to submit it, whereas the other contacts will only be able to edit the parts related to their personal data.
- Be aware that only one person should work on the forms at any given time. If two persons work on the forms at the same time, in case of a save conflict, the last save wins, which means that you risk overwriting changes made by another person if you are working in parallel. We therefore recommend that you give 'read-only' access to your partners/additional contact persons (other contacts) unless it is absolutely necessary to grant full access. Please remember that the host institution main contact person has full access – it is not possible to grant them 'read-only access'.
- Up to the call deadline, it is possible to re-edit, download or withdraw a proposal. **ONLY the last updated version of your proposal submitted before the deadline will be evaluated;** no later version can be accepted and no earlier version can be recovered from the submission system. Once the deadline has passed, no further additions, corrections or resubmissions are accepted. However, a read-only access to the submitted proposal is available for 90 days after the call deadline.
- **Do submit your proposal as early as possible** (at least 48 hours prior to the deadline of the call) to avoid being confronted with last minute issues shortly before the call deadline. There is no reason in delaying the submission for confidentiality concerns as the system does not allow any access to the proposals before call deadline (other than to selected data that is part of the Submission and Evaluation of Proposals Assent Disclaimer).
- In some rare occasions, the proposal may be altered while converted into a PDF file. Before uploading the file, please check that everything is correct. Additionally, please download and verify all uploaded files in due time before the submission deadline.

The proposal is submitted only if the sequence described in point 3.2 below has been finalised and not when the applicant starts uploading the proposal.

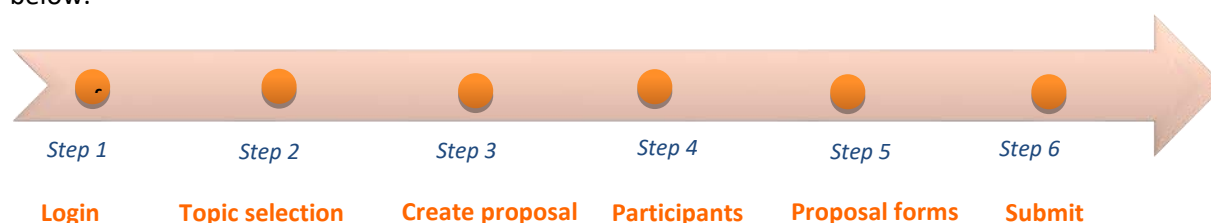
3.2 HOW TO APPLY

The ERC grant applications can only be submitted in response to a 'call for proposals' and only via the Electronic Submission Service. Calls announced in the [ERC WP 2027](#) are published on the [ERC website](#) and the [F&T Portal](#).

USER GUIDANCE

- proposals must be submitted electronically using the electronic submission service of the web-based [F&T Portal](#)⁵⁵;
- the [user manual](#) of the Submission Service is available online;
- the F&T Portal [Online Manual](#) describes the standard process of proposal submission.

The electronic submission system is an online wizard that guides you step-by-step through the preparation of your proposal. The submission of an ERC proposal includes 6 steps as described below.



Steps 1 & 2: “Login” and “Topic Selection”

To be able to submit a proposal and, in general, to login to the F&T Portal, you must first register an EU Login account (Step 1). Please note that you should not use the “eID sign-in” option when creating an account, as this will create an account with limited editing rights – such an account cannot edit and submit an ERC proposal. Each time you access the proposal for editing, this user ID is requested. The same user ID is used for all later interactions with the ERCEA, including notification of the results of the evaluation⁵⁶. Under 'Search Topics' you may search for 'ERC' to select an open ERC call (Step 2). Soon after the opening of the call, you may access the Electronic Submission Service via the F&T Portal call page. The 'Start Submission' button is available in the 'Submission Service' section of the call. When you click 'Start Submission' and confirm the call selection, you will arrive to Step 3 – Create a Draft proposal.

Step 3: “Create proposal”

At this step, you fill in pre-registration data for the proposal. These details will be used by the ERCEA in order to plan the evaluation. You will not have access to this page again once it is completed and you have progressed to Step 4, but certain data such as Acronym (maximum 20 characters) and Short Summary (abstract) can be modified at a later stage (at Step 5, when editing the submission form). **Be careful to choose the correct Participant Identification Code (PIC) number for your host institution.** An [online tool](#) is available to search for existing PICs and the related organisations. Organisations not yet having a PIC must self-register (via the same page) before starting the application process.

⁵⁵ In duly justified exceptional circumstances, the ERCEA may authorise submission by means other than the electronic submission system.

⁵⁶ Further details are available here: <https://webgate.ec.europa.eu/cnpn/>.

Step 4: “Participants”

At this step, you **MUST** enter the name and e-mail of the Principal Investigator and the Main host institution Contact person⁵⁷. You may also add the LEAR as a contact person (e.g. as a team member with read-only rights). **Please note that these contact details are saved directly from this step into the administrative form. Hence, this data is not editable in the application form itself. Still, you can at any point return to Step 4 to add or delete any contact person or to change the access rights. Remember to save your data before leaving Step 4 and to open and save the form as well** (Step 5 below). Once the coordinator saves the changes, an automatic invitation is sent to all contacts' e-mail addresses. The invited persons can access the proposal after logging in to the F&T Portal – with the EU login account linked to the given e-mail address – under the 'My Proposals' tab.

If they have not yet registered an EU login account, the Principal Investigator or the applicant legal entity's contact person will receive an activation e-mail inviting them to activate their EU login account. Following to this first activation, the EU login account will be maintained for following communications or feedback. **In order to be able to submit your proposal after saving changes made in Step 4, you have to re-open the administrative form ('edit forms' button), revise the changes, validate and save the form.** Failure to do so will prevent you from submitting your proposal. Further details are available in the Submission Service [user manual](#).

Step 5: “Proposal forms”

This step is the core of the submission process, as from this step, you **can edit** the online administrative **forms** ('edit forms' button), you can go back to the 'Participants' step, you can view the 'history', 'print preview' the draft proposal, 'download' **Part B templates**, '**upload**' files, '**validate**' the forms and '**submit**' the proposal by clicking on the relevant buttons. Guidance on how to fill in the administrative forms is provided directly in the form as ghost text for the single entries or as additional help text hidden behind question-marks . Some parts of the form will be prefilled based on the data entered at pre-registration or in the Beneficiary Register. **Please use the functionality 'Validate' button to check the validity and completeness of your data.** Any warning or error will be listed at the end of the validated form. Please see [Annex 4.6](#) for a list of mandatory fields. **If one or several mandatory fields are not filled, it will prevent you from submitting your proposal.**

Further information on the preparation of the application (the online administrative forms and Proposal Parts B1 and B2) is given in [section 2](#) of this document.

- **All files must be uploaded in the submission system as PDF ('portable document format'). Other file formats will not be accepted by the system.** Irrespective of any page limits specified in this document, there is an **overall limit of 10 Mbytes to the size of each uploaded document (Part B1, Part B2, and supporting documentation)**. However, it is advised to limit the size of Parts B1 and B2 to 2 Mbytes each.
- Unless specified in the call, embedded material and any other documents (company brochures, scientific papers, reports, audio, video, multimedia, links, etc.) sent either electronically or by post to the ERCEA or uploaded directly in the F&T Portal will be disregarded.

There are also restrictions to the name given to the Part B files: use alphanumeric characters; special characters and spaces must be avoided. You are advised to clean your document before converting it to PDF (e.g. accept all tracked changes, delete notes). Check that your conversion software has

⁵⁷ Be careful to type the correct e-mail address of the Principal Investigator and all contact persons at this step. Please note that if the Principal Investigator and the administrative contact person is the same person (because the Principal Investigator is self-employed), you must use two different e-mail addresses as the system does not allow two identical e-mail addresses to be entered.

successfully converted all the pages of your original document (e.g. there is no problem with page limits or page view), and that captions and labels have not been lost from your diagrams.

Completing the Proposal submission forms in the submission system and uploading all the necessary files does not yet mean that your proposal is submitted (mandatory files: Part B1, Part B2, PhD certificate, host institution support letter and -if applicable- supporting documentation for eligibility extension and/or ethics and security issues). Once there is a consolidated version of the proposal, **the 'SUBMIT' button must be pressed.** The system performs a limited automatic validation of the proposal. Any problems such as missing data, wrong file format or excessive file size will appear as a list of warnings and/or errors on the screen. You may submit your proposal with warnings (marked in yellow) by clicking again on the "submit" button, but it is not possible to submit a proposal until all errors (marked in red) are corrected. Please note that the electronic checks by the submission system do not replace the formal admissibility and eligibility review and do not confirm that the contents of these files respond to the requirements of the call.

Step 6: "Submit"

By hitting the 'Submit' button, the proposal is submitted (i.e. sent to the ERCEA for evaluation). It does not mean that the proposal is valid, admissible and eligible in all respects. Within a few minutes of submission, your proposal will be available for download with an e-receipt in the system. You will receive a confirmation e-mail with the summary data of the submitted proposal. The mail can end up in the spam folder or be blocked by the anti-spam system of your organisation. This automatic message is not the official acknowledgement of receipt. In Step 6, you can re-edit the proposal, going back to Step 5. **You may continue to modify the proposal and submit revised versions overwriting the previous one right up until the call deadline.** The sequence above must be repeated each time. The most recent version of your proposal submitted before the deadline is the one which will be evaluated. No earlier version can be recovered from the submission system.

Check if the proposal is complete. Once submitted, it is recommended to verify the proposal and its content by downloading all the submitted files. We strongly advise that you submit a first version of your proposal at least 48 hours in advance of the call deadline. Incomplete proposals (where parts or sections of the proposal and/or the host institution's commitment statement are missing) may be declared inadmissible and will not be evaluated⁵⁸. The proposal must be submitted **before the relevant deadline of the call** to the appropriate primary ERC panel (i.e. the panel which covers the main scientific areas of the research proposed).

Warning: Please note that in the last hours prior to call closure, the download option of checking your submitted proposal may be disabled due to a high pressure on the system. In this case, the ERCEA will inform the applicants via the call page on the [F&T Portal](#) (under 'call summary') that the function has been disabled. **If the e-receipt and download option have been disabled, you may review your submitted proposal by going back to Step 5 in order to check the data in the administrative forms and click on 'View History' to verify which attachments have been uploaded.**

⁵⁸ See also section 2.4 'Admissibility and eligibility check' in the [ERC Rules of Submission and Evaluation under Horizon Europe](#) and in the section "Proposal submission and description" of the [ERC WP 2027](#).

3.3 HOW TO WITHDRAW A PROPOSAL

A submitted proposal may be withdrawn either by the Principal Investigator or by the Host Institution with the consent of the Principal Investigator.

To withdraw a proposal **before the call deadline**, use the "withdraw proposal" button from the 'My proposals' tab when logged in at the F&T Portal. After the call deadline, proposals may be withdrawn at any moment **until the day preceding the panel meeting**⁵⁹ where a final decision on the outcome of the evaluation of the proposal is established. A withdrawn proposal will not be considered for evaluation nor count against possible re-application restrictions as set out in the ERC Work Programme 2027.

To withdraw a proposal **after the call deadline**, please send a message/letter indicating a clear and unambiguous intention to withdraw the proposal, to the call-specific mailbox ERC-2027-STG-APPLICANTS@ec.europa.eu or ERC-2027-COG-APPLICANTS@ec.europa.eu. The message/letter should mention the name of the Principal Investigator, the proposal number and the acronym of the proposal as well as the call identifier (for example ERC-2027-STG). The applicant Principal Investigator should use an e-mail address indicated in their application. If the message/letter is sent by the host institution representative, the applicant Principal Investigator should be in copy of an e-mail containing such a message/letter.

In the case of two or more proposals submitted by the same Principal Investigator, the ERCEA services may ask the Principal Investigator to withdraw one or more of those proposals. In the case of absence of reaction by the Principal Investigator to this request, only the first eligible submitted proposal will be evaluated.

⁵⁹ Please refer to the indicative dates provided in 'Evaluation process and important dates' under section '1.3 EVALUATION PROCESS'

4. ANNEXES

4.1 ERC EVALUATION PANELS AND KEYWORDS

Physical Sciences and Engineering

PE1 Mathematics

All areas of mathematics, pure and applied, plus mathematical foundations of computer science, mathematical physics and statistics

- PE1_1 Logic and foundations
- PE1_2 Algebra
- PE1_3 Number theory
- PE1_4 Algebraic and complex geometry
- PE1_5 Differential geometry, global analysis and Lie theory
- PE1_6 Topology, algebraic topology, topological data analysis
- PE1_7 Analysis and functional analysis
- PE1_8 Dynamical systems and ordinary differential equations
- PE1_9 Partial differential equations
- PE1_10 Mathematical physics
- PE1_11 Probability
- PE1_12 Discrete mathematics and combinatorics
- PE1_13 Mathematics of computer and data science, and of artificial intelligence
- PE1_14 Numerical analysis and scientific computing
- PE1_15 Control theory, optimisation and operational research
- PE1_16 Mathematical statistics, generic statistical methodology and modelling
- PE1_17 Mathematics in sciences – mathematics in biology and other science fields
- PE1_18 Mathematics for industrial and societal challenges

PE2 Fundamental Constituents of Matter

Particle, nuclear, plasma, atomic, molecular, gas, and optical physics

- PE2_1 Theory of fundamental interactions
- PE2_2 Phenomenology of fundamental interactions
- PE2_3 Experimental particle physics with accelerators
- PE2_4 Experimental particle physics without accelerators
- PE2_5 Classical and quantum physics of gravitational interactions
- PE2_6 Nuclear, hadron and heavy ion physics
- PE2_7 Nuclear and particle astrophysics
- PE2_8 Gas and plasma physics
- PE2_9 Electromagnetism
- PE2_10 Atomic, molecular physics
- PE2_11 Ultra-cold atoms and molecules
- PE2_12 Optics, non-linear optics and nano-optics
- PE2_13 Quantum optics and quantum information
- PE2_14 Lasers, ultra-short lasers and laser physics
- PE2_15 Thermodynamics
- PE2_16 Non-linear physics
- PE2_17 Metrology and measurement
- PE2_18 Equilibrium and non-equilibrium statistical mechanics: steady states and dynamics

PE3 Condensed Matter Physics

Structure, electronic properties, fluids, nanosciences, biological physics

- PE3_1 Structure of solids, material growth and characterisation
- PE3_2 Mechanical and acoustical properties of condensed matter, lattice dynamics
- PE3_3 Transport properties of condensed matter
- PE3_4 Electronic properties of materials, surfaces, interfaces, nanostructures
- PE3_5 Physical properties of semiconductors and insulators
- PE3_6 Macroscopic quantum phenomena, e.g. superconductivity, superfluidity, quantum Hall effect
- PE3_7 Spintronics
- PE3_8 Magnetism and strongly correlated systems
- PE3_9 Condensed matter – beam interactions (photons, electrons, etc.)
- PE3_10 Nanophysics, e.g. nanoelectronics, nanophotonics, nanomagnetism, nanoelectromechanics
- PE3_11 Mesoscopic quantum physics and solid-state quantum technologies
- PE3_12 Molecular electronics
- PE3_13 Structure and dynamics of disordered systems, e.g. soft matter (gels, colloids, liquid crystals), granular matter, liquids, glasses, defects
- PE3_14 Fluid dynamics (physics)
- PE3_15 Statistical physics: phase transitions, condensed matter systems, models of complex systems, interdisciplinary applications
- PE3_16 Physics of biological systems

PE4 Physical and Analytical Chemical Sciences

Analytical chemistry, chemical theory, physical chemistry/chemical physics

- PE4_1 Physical chemistry
- PE4_2 Spectroscopic and spectrometric techniques
- PE4_3 Molecular architecture and Structure
- PE4_4 Surface science and nanostructures
- PE4_5 Analytical chemistry
- PE4_6 Chemical physics
- PE4_7 Chemical instrumentation
- PE4_8 Electrochemistry, electrodialysis, microfluidics, sensors
- PE4_9 Method development in chemistry
- PE4_10 Heterogeneous catalysis
- PE4_11 Physical chemistry of biological systems
- PE4_12 Chemical reactions: mechanisms, dynamics, kinetics and catalytic reactions
- PE4_13 Theoretical and computational chemistry
- PE4_14 Radiation and Nuclear chemistry
- PE4_15 Photochemistry
- PE4_16 Corrosion
- PE4_17 Characterisation methods of materials
- PE4_18 Environment chemistry

PE5 Synthetic Chemistry and Materials

New materials and new synthetic approaches, structure-properties relations, solid state chemistry, molecular architecture, organic chemistry

- PE5_1 Structural properties of materials
- PE5_2 Solid state materials chemistry
- PE5_3 Surface modification
- PE5_4 Thin films
- PE5_5 Ionic liquids
- PE5_6 New materials: oxides, alloys, composite, organic-inorganic hybrid, nanoparticles
- PE5_7 Biomaterials synthesis
- PE5_8 Intelligent materials synthesis – self assembled materials

- PE5_9 Coordination chemistry
- PE5_10 Colloid chemistry
- PE5_11 Biological chemistry and chemical biology
- PE5_12 Chemistry of condensed matter
- PE5_13 Homogeneous catalysis
- PE5_14 Macromolecular chemistry
- PE5_15 Polymer chemistry
- PE5_16 Supramolecular chemistry
- PE5_17 Organic chemistry
- PE5_18 Medicinal chemistry

PE6 Computer Science and Informatics

Theoretical and experimental computer science, information processing, intelligent systems

- PE6_1 Computer architecture, high-performance computing, real-time and embedded systems
- PE6_2 Operating and distributed systems, computer networks and performance evaluation, mobile computing
- PE6_3 Software engineering, programming languages
- PE6_4 Theory of computation, semantics of computation, formal methods
- PE6_5 Algorithms, complexity theory, algorithmic game theory and computational economics
- PE6_6 Security, privacy, cryptology
- PE6_7 Databases, web and information systems, information retrieval
- PE6_8 Artificial intelligence, autonomous agents, knowledge representation
- PE6_9 Machine learning, statistical data processing, computing with artificial neural networks
- PE6_10 Natural language processing, large language and other foundation models
- PE6_11 Computer vision, computer graphics, visualization
- PE6_12 Human computer interaction, multimedia and virtual reality, computer games
- PE6_13 Numerical and scientific computing, computational modelling and simulation methods, bioinformatics
- PE6_14 New computational paradigms, quantum computing, bio-inspired computing

PE7 Systems and Communication Engineering

Electrical, electronic, communication, optical and systems engineering

- PE7_1 Control engineering
- PE7_2 Electrical engineering: power components and/or systems
- PE7_3 Simulation engineering and modelling
- PE7_4 (Micro- and nano-) systems engineering
- PE7_5 (Micro- and nano-) electronic, optoelectronic and photonic components
- PE7_6 Communication systems, wireless technology, high-frequency technology
- PE7_7 Signal processing
- PE7_8 Networks, e.g. communication networks and nodes, Internet of Things, sensor networks, networks of robots
- PE7_9 Human-machine interfaces
- PE7_10 Robotics
- PE7_11 Components and systems for applications (in e.g. medicine, biology, environment)
- PE7_12 Electrical energy production, distribution, applications

PE8 Products and Processes Engineering

Product and process design, chemical, civil, environmental, mechanical, vehicle engineering, energy processes and relevant computational methods

- PE8_1 Aerospace engineering
- PE8_2 Chemical engineering, technical chemistry
- PE8_3 Civil engineering, architecture, offshore construction, lightweight construction, geotechnics
- PE8_4 Computational engineering

- PE8_5 Fluid mechanics
- PE8_6 Energy processes engineering
- PE8_7 Mechanical engineering
- PE8_8 Propulsion engineering, e.g. hydraulic, turbo, piston, hybrid engines
- PE8_9 Production technology, process engineering
- PE8_10 Manufacturing engineering and industrial design
- PE8_11 Environmental engineering, e.g. sustainable design, waste and water treatment, recycling, regeneration or recovery of compounds, carbon capture & storage
- PE8_12 Naval/marine engineering
- PE8_13 Automotive and rail engineering; multi-/inter-modal transport engineering
- PE8_14 Heat and mass transfer engineering

PE9 Universe Sciences

Astro-physics/-chemistry/-biology; solar system; planetary systems; stellar, galactic and extragalactic astronomy; cosmology; space sciences; astronomical instrumentation and data

- PE9_1 Solar physics – the Sun and the heliosphere
- PE9_2 Solar system science
- PE9_3 Exoplanetary science, formation and characterization of extrasolar planets
- PE9_4 Astrochemistry and astrobiology
- PE9_5 Interstellar medium and star formation
- PE9_6 Stars – stellar physics, stellar systems
- PE9_7 The Milky Way
- PE9_8 Galaxies – formation, evolution, clusters
- PE9_9 Cosmology and large-scale structure, dark matter, dark energy
- PE9_10 Relativistic astrophysics and compact objects
- PE9_11 Gravitational wave astrophysics and multimessenger astronomy
- PE9_12 High-energy and particle astronomy
- PE9_13 Astronomical instrumentation, e.g. telescopes, detectors, techniques
- PE9_14 Analysis and archiving of astronomical data, and use of AI in astronomy

PE10 Earth System Science

Physical geography, geology, geophysics, atmospheric sciences, oceanography, climatology, cryology, ecology, global environmental change, biogeochemical cycles, natural resources management

- PE10_1 Atmospheric chemistry, atmospheric composition, air pollution
- PE10_2 Meteorology, atmospheric physics and dynamics
- PE10_3 Climatology and climate change
- PE10_4 Terrestrial ecology, land cover change
- PE10_5 Geology, tectonics, volcanology
- PE10_6 Palaeoclimatology, palaeoecology
- PE10_7 Physics of earth's interior, seismology, geodynamics
- PE10_8 Oceanography (physical, chemical, biological, geological)
- PE10_9 Biogeochemistry, biogeochemical cycles, environmental chemistry
- PE10_10 Mineralogy, petrology, igneous petrology, metamorphic petrology
- PE10_11 Geochemistry, cosmochemistry, crystal chemistry, isotope geochemistry, thermodynamics
- PE10_12 Sedimentology, soil science, palaeontology, earth evolution
- PE10_13 Physical geography, geomorphology
- PE10_14 Earth observations from space/remote sensing
- PE10_15 Geomagnetism, palaeomagnetism
- PE10_16 Ozone, upper atmosphere, ionosphere
- PE10_17 Hydrology, hydrogeology, engineering and environmental geology, water and soil pollution
- PE10_18 Cryosphere, dynamics of snow and ice cover, sea ice, permafrosts and ice sheets
- PE10_19 Planetary geology and geophysics
- PE10_20 Geohazards
- PE10_21 Earth system modelling and interactions

PE11 Materials Engineering

Advanced materials development: performance enhancement, modelling, large-scale preparation, modification, tailoring, optimisation, novel and combined use of materials, etc.

PE11_1 Engineering of biomaterials, biomimetic, bioinspired and bio-enabled materials

PE11_2 Engineering of metals and alloys

PE11_3 Engineering of ceramics and glasses

PE11_4 Engineering of polymers and plastics

PE11_5 Engineering of composites and hybrid materials

PE11_6 Engineering of carbon materials

PE11_7 Engineering of metal oxides

PE11_8 Engineering of alternative established or emergent materials

PE11_9 Nanomaterials engineering, e.g. nanoparticles, nanoporous materials, 1D & 2D nanomaterials

PE11_10 Soft materials engineering, e.g. gels, foams, colloids

PE11_11 Porous materials engineering, e.g. covalent-organic, metal-organic, porous aromatic frameworks

PE11_12 Semi-conducting and magnetic materials engineering

PE11_13 Metamaterials engineering

PE11_14 Computational methods for materials engineering

Life Sciences

LS1 Molecules of Life: Biological Mechanisms, Structures and Functions

For all organisms:

Molecular biology, biochemistry, structural biology, molecular biophysics, synthetic and chemical biology, drug design, innovative methods and modelling

- LS1_1 Macromolecular complexes including interactions involving nucleic acids, proteins, lipids and carbohydrates
- LS1_2 Biochemistry
- LS1_3 DNA and RNA biology
- LS1_4 Protein biology
- LS1_5 Lipid biology
- LS1_6 Glycobiology
- LS1_7 Molecular biophysics, biomechanics, bioenergetics
- LS1_8 Structural biology
- LS1_9 Molecular mechanisms of signalling processes
- LS1_10 Synthetic biology
- LS1_11 Chemical biology
- LS1_12 Protein design
- LS1_13 Early translational research and drug design
- LS1_14 Innovative methods and modelling in molecular, structural and synthetic biology

LS2 Integrative Biology: from Genes and Genomes to Systems

For all organisms:

Genetics, epigenetics, genomics and other 'omics studies, bioinformatics, systems biology, genetic diseases, gene editing, innovative methods and modelling, 'omics for personalised medicine

- LS2_1 Genetics
- LS2_2 Gene editing
- LS2_3 Epigenetics
- LS2_4 Gene regulation
- LS2_5 Genomics
- LS2_6 Metagenomics
- LS2_7 Transcriptomics
- LS2_8 Proteomics
- LS2_9 Metabolomics
- LS2_10 Glycomics/Lipidomics
- LS2_11 Bioinformatics and computational biology
- LS2_12 Biostatistics
- LS2_13 Systems biology
- LS2_14 Genetic diseases
- LS2_15 Integrative biology for personalised medicine
- LS2_16 Innovative methods and modelling in integrative biology

LS3 Cell Biology, Development, Stem Cells and Regeneration

For all organisms:

Structure and function of the cell, cell-cell communication, embryogenesis, tissue differentiation, organogenesis, growth, development, evolution of development, organoids, stem cells, regeneration, therapeutic approaches

- LS3_1 Cell cycle, cell division and growth
- LS3_2 Cell senescence, cell death, autophagy, cell ageing
- LS3_3 Cell behaviour, including control of cell shape, cell migration
- LS3_4 Cell junctions, cell adhesion, the extracellular matrix, cell communication

- LS3_5 Cell signalling and signal transduction, exosome biology
- LS3_6 Organelle biology and trafficking
- LS3_7 Mechanobiology of cells, tissues and organs
- LS3_8 Embryogenesis, pattern formation, morphogenesis
- LS3_9 Cell differentiation, formation of tissues and organs
- LS3_10 Developmental genetics
- LS3_11 Evolution of developmental strategies
- LS3_12 Organoids
- LS3_13 Stem cells
- LS3_14 Regeneration
- LS3_15 Development of cell-based therapeutic approaches for tissue regeneration
- LS3_16 Functional imaging of cells and tissues
- LS3_17 Theoretical modelling in cellular, developmental and regenerative biology

LS4 Physiology in Health, Disease and Ageing

Organ and tissue physiology, comparative physiology, physiology of ageing, pathophysiology, inter-organ and tissue communication, endocrinology, nutrition, metabolism, interaction with the microbiome, non-communicable diseases including cancer (and except disorders of the nervous system and immunity-related diseases)

- LS4_1 Organ and tissue physiology and pathophysiology
- LS4_2 Comparative physiology
- LS4_3 Physiology of ageing
- LS4_4 Endocrinology
- LS4_5 Non-hormonal mechanisms of inter-organ and tissue communication
- LS4_6 Microbiome and host physiology
- LS4_7 Nutrition and exercise physiology
- LS4_8 Impact of stress (including environmental stress) on physiology
- LS4_9 Metabolism and metabolic disorders, including diabetes and obesity
- LS4_10 The cardiovascular system and cardiovascular diseases
- LS4_11 Haematopoiesis and blood diseases
- LS4_12 Cancer
- LS4_13 Other non-communicable diseases (except disorders of the nervous system and immunity-related diseases)

LS5 Neuroscience and Disorders of the Nervous System

Nervous system development, homeostasis and ageing, nervous system function and dysfunction, systems neuroscience and modelling, biological basis of cognitive processes and of behaviour, neurological and mental disorders

– *In humans and all other organisms*

- LS5_1 Neuronal cells
- LS5_2 Glial cells and neuronal-glial communication
- LS5_3 Neural development and related disorders
- LS5_4 Neural stem cells
- LS5_5 Neural networks and plasticity
- LS5_6 Neurovascular biology and blood-brain barrier
- LS5_7 Sensory systems, sensation and perception, including pain
- LS5_8 Neural basis of behaviour (e.g. sleep, consciousness, addiction)
- LS5_9 Neural basis of cognition (e.g. learning, memory, attention, emotions, speech)
- LS5_10 Ageing of the nervous system
- LS5_11 Neurological and neurodegenerative disorders
- LS5_12 Mental disorders
- LS5_13 Nervous system injuries and trauma, stroke
- LS5_14 Repair and regeneration of the nervous system
- LS5_15 Neuroimmunology, neuroinflammation

- LS5_16 Systems and computational neuroscience (e.g. modelling, simulation, brain oscillations, connectomics)
- LS5_17 Imaging in neuroscience
- LS5_18 Innovative methods and tools for neuroscience

LS6 Immunity, Infection and Immunotherapy

The immune system, related disorders and their mechanisms, biology of infectious agents and infection, biological basis of prevention and treatment of infectious diseases, innovative immunological tools and approaches, including therapies

- LS6_1 Innate immunity
- LS6_2 Adaptive immunity
- LS6_3 Regulation of the immune response
- LS6_4 Immune-related diseases
- LS6_5 Biology of pathogens (e.g. bacteria, viruses, parasites, fungi)
- LS6_6 Infectious diseases
- LS6_7 Mechanisms of infection
- LS6_8 Biological basis of prevention and treatment of infection
- LS6_9 Antimicrobials, antimicrobial resistance
- LS6_10 Vaccine development
- LS6_11 Innovative immunological tools and approaches, including therapies

LS7 Prevention, Diagnosis and Treatment of Human Diseases

Medical technologies and tools for prevention, diagnosis and treatment of human diseases, therapeutic approaches and interventions, pharmacology, preventative medicine, epidemiology and public health, digital medicine

- LS7_1 Medical imaging for prevention, diagnosis and monitoring of diseases
- LS7_2 Medical technologies and tools (including genetic tools and biomarkers) for prevention, diagnosis, monitoring and treatment of diseases
- LS7_3 Nanomedicine
- LS7_4 Regenerative medicine
- LS7_5 Applied gene, cell and immune therapies
- LS7_6 Other medical therapeutic interventions, including transplantation
- LS7_7 Pharmacology and toxicology
- LS7_8 Effectiveness of interventions, including resistance to therapies
- LS7_9 Public health and epidemiology
- LS7_10 Preventative and prognostic medicine
- LS7_11 Environmental health, occupational medicine
- LS7_12 Health care, including care for the ageing population
- LS7_13 Palliative medicine
- LS7_14 Digital medicine, e-medicine, medical applications of artificial intelligence
- LS7_15 Medical ethics

LS8 Environmental Biology, Ecology and Evolution

For all organisms:

Ecology, biodiversity, environmental change, evolutionary biology, behavioural ecology, microbial ecology, marine biology, ecophysiology, theoretical developments and modelling

- LS8_1 Ecosystem and community ecology, macroecology
- LS8_2 Biodiversity
- LS8_3 Conservation biology
- LS8_4 Population biology, population dynamics, population genetics
- LS8_5 Biological aspects of environmental change, including climate change
- LS8_6 Evolutionary ecology
- LS8_7 Evolutionary genetics
- LS8_8 Phylogenetics, systematics, comparative biology

- LS8_9 Macroeolution and paleobiology
- LS8_10 Ecology and evolution of species interactions
- LS8_11 Behavioural ecology and evolution
- LS8_12 Microbial ecology and evolution
- LS8_13 Marine biology and ecology
- LS8_14 Ecophysiology, from organisms to ecosystems
- LS8_15 Theoretical developments and modelling in environmental biology, ecology, and evolution

LS9 Biotechnology and Biosystems Engineering

Biotechnology using all organisms, biotechnology for environment and food applications, applied plant and animal sciences, bioengineering and synthetic biology, biomass and biofuels, biohazards

- LS9_1 Bioengineering for synthetic and chemical biology
- LS9_2 Applied genetics, gene editing and transgenic organisms
- LS9_3 Bioengineering of cells, tissues, organs and organisms
- LS9_4 Microbial biotechnology and bioengineering
- LS9_5 Food biotechnology and bioengineering
- LS9_6 Marine biotechnology and bioengineering
- LS9_7 Environmental biotechnology and bioengineering
- LS9_8 Applied plant sciences, plant breeding, agroecology and soil biology
- LS9_9 Plant pathology and pest resistance
- LS9_10 Veterinary and applied animal sciences
- LS9_11 Biomass production and utilisation, biofuels
- LS9_12 Ecotoxicology, biohazards and biosafety

Social Sciences and Humanities

SH1 Individuals, Markets and Organisations

Economics, finance, management

- SH1_1 Macroeconomics; monetary economics; economic growth, labour economics
- SH1_2 International trade; international business; spatial economics
- SH1_3 Development economics political economics
- SH1_4 Finance; financial markets
- SH1_5 Corporate finance; international finance
- SH1_6 Banking, insurance
- SH1_7 Accounting, asset prices, auditing
- SH1_8 Econometrics, game theory, decision theory
- SH1_9 Behavioural economics; experimental economics; neuro-economics
- SH1_10 Microeconomics, industrial organisation, applied microeconomics
- SH1_11 Innovation, research & development, entrepreneurship
- SH1_12 Management; operations management, international management
- SH1_13 Human resource management; organisational behaviour
- SH1_14 Strategy, operation research
- SH1_15 Marketing, consumer behaviour
- SH1_16 Quantitative economic history, economic systems, institutional economics

SH2 Institutions, Governance and Legal Systems

Political science, international relations, law

- SH2_1 Political systems, governance
- SH2_2 Democratisation and social movements
- SH2_3 Conflict resolution, war, peace building
- SH2_4 Legal studies, comparative law, law and economics
- SH2_5 Constitutions, human rights, international law
- SH2_6 International relations, global and transnational governance
- SH2_7 Humanitarian assistance and development
- SH2_8 Political and legal philosophy
- SH2_9 Digital approaches to political science and law

SH3 The Social World and Its Interactions

Sociology, social psychology, education sciences, communication studies

- SH3_1 Social structure, social mobility, social innovation
- SH3_2 Inequalities, discrimination, prejudice
- SH3_3 Gender, ethnicity, diversity, identity
- SH3_4 Aggression and violence, antisocial behaviour, crime
- SH3_5 Social integration, exclusion, prosocial behaviour
- SH3_6 Social attitudes and beliefs
- SH3_7 Social influence; power and group behaviour
- SH3_8 Social policies, welfare, work and employment
- SH3_9 Poverty and poverty alleviation
- SH3_10 Social aspects of teaching and learning, curriculum studies, education and educational policies
- SH3_11 Communication and information, networks, media
- SH3_12 Digital social research
- SH3_13 Social studies of science and technology

SH4 The Human Mind and Its Complexity

Cognitive science, psychology, linguistics

- SH4_1 Cognitive basis of human development, developmental disorders; comparative cognition
- SH4_2 Personality and social cognition; emotion
- SH4_3 Clinical and health psychology

- SH4_4 Neurocognitive psychology
- SH4_5 Attention, perception, action, consciousness
- SH4_6 Learning, memory; cognition in ageing
- SH4_7 Reasoning, decision-making; intelligence
- SH4_8 Language learning and processing (first and second languages)
- SH4_9 Theoretical linguistics; computational linguistics
- SH4_10 Language typology; historical linguistics
- SH4_11 Pragmatics, sociolinguistics, linguistic anthropology, discourse analysis

SH5 Texts and Concepts

Literary studies, literature, philosophy

- SH5_1 Classics, ancient literature
- SH5_2 Theory and history of literature, comparative literature
- SH5_3 Book studies
- SH5_4 Philology; text and image studies
- SH5_5 Palaeography and codicology
- SH5_6 Philosophy of mind, philosophy of language
- SH5_7 Philosophy of science, epistemology, logic
- SH5_8 Metaphysics, philosophical anthropology; aesthetics
- SH5_9 Ethics and its applications; social philosophy
- SH5_10 History of philosophy
- SH5_11 Digital humanities; digital approaches to literary studies and philosophy

SH6 The Study of the Human Past

Archaeology and history

- SH6_1 Archaeological methods and theory, history of archaeology
- SH6_2 Prehistoric archaeology, archaeology of non-literate societies
- SH6_3 Archaeology of early literate societies and early civilizations
- SH6_4 Medieval and post-medieval archaeologies
- SH6_5 Archaeological science, bioarchaeology, environmental archaeology, geoarchaeology
- SH6_6 Digital, computational, virtual and geospatial archaeologies
- SH6_7 Historiography, theory and methods of history, including the analysis of digital data
- SH6_8 Ancient history, medieval history
- SH6_9 Early modern, modern, and contemporary history
- SH6_10 Colonial and post-colonial history
- SH6_11 Global, transnational, and comparative history
- SH6_12 Social and economic history
- SH6_13 Cultural history, intellectual history
- SH6_14 History of science and technologies, environmental history

SH7 Human Mobility, Environment, and Space

Human geography, demography, health, sustainability science, territorial planning, spatial analysis

- SH7_1 Human, economic and social geography
- SH7_2 Migration
- SH7_3 Population dynamics: households, family and fertility
- SH7_4 Social aspects of health, ageing and society
- SH7_5 Sustainability sciences, environment and resources, ecosystem services
- SH7_6 Environmental and climate change, societal impact and policy
- SH7_7 Cities; urban, regional and rural studies
- SH7_8 Land use and planning
- SH7_9 Energy, transportation and mobility
- SH7_10 GIS, spatial analysis; digital geography

SH8 Arts, Cultures and Societies

Anthropology, studies of cultures and the arts

- SH8_1 Social and cultural anthropology
- SH8_2 Kinship, diversities and identities, gender, interethnic relations
- SH8_3 Religious studies, rituals, symbolic representations
- SH8_4 Cultural studies and theory, cultural identities and memories, cultural heritage
- SH8_5 Cultural heritage, museums, exhibitions, conservation and restoration
- SH8_6 History of art and of architecture, visual studies
- SH8_7 Architecture, design, craft, creative industries
- SH8_8 Music studies, sound studies
- SH8_9 Performance studies, arts-based research
- SH8_10 Film and television studies, media studies
- SH8_11 Digital approaches to anthropology, cultural studies and art

4.2 HOST INSTITUTION SUPPORT LETTER TEMPLATE 2027

Commitment of the host institution for ERC Calls 2027^{60, 61, 62}

The <<please fill in here the name of the legal entity that is associated to the proposal and may host the principal investigator and the project (action) in case the application is successful>>, which is the applicant legal entity,

confirms its intention to sign a supplementary agreement with
<<please fill in here the name of the principal investigator>>

in which the obligations listed below will be addressed should the proposal be retained.

Performance obligations of the *applicant legal entity* (host institution) that will become the coordinator of the HE ERC Grant Agreement (hereafter referred to as the Agreement), should the proposal be retained and the preparation of the Agreement be successfully concluded:

The applicant legal entity (host institution) commits itself to ensure that the action tasks described in Annex 1 of the Agreement are performed under the guidance of the principal investigator who is expected to devote:

- in the case of a Starting Grant at least 50% of her/his working time to the ERC-funded project (action) and spend at least 50% of her/his working time in an EU Member State or Associated Country;
- in the case of a Consolidator Grant at least 40% of her/his working time to the ERC-funded project (action) and spend at least 50% of her/his working time in an EU Member State or Associated Country;
- in the case of an Advanced Grant at least 30% of her/his working time to the ERC-funded project (action) and spend at least 50% of her/his working time in an EU Member State or Associated Country.

The applicant legal entity (host institution) commits itself to respect the following conditions for the principal investigator and their team:

- a) host and engage the principal investigator for the whole duration of the action;
- b) take all measures to implement the principles set out in the Commission recommendation on the European Charter for Researchers and the Code of Conduct for the Recruitment of Researchers⁶³ — in particular regarding working conditions,

⁶⁰ A scanned copy of the signed statement should be uploaded electronically via the EU [Funding & Tenders Portal](#) Submission Service in PDF format.

⁶¹ The statement of commitment of the host institution refers to most obligations of the host institution, which are stated in the Model Grant Agreement used for ERC actions (MGA). The [MGA](#) is available on the EU Funding & Tenders Portal. The reference to the time commitment of the principal investigator is stated in the ERC Work Programme 2027.

⁶² This statement (on letterhead paper) shall be signed with a legally binding signature (e.g. blue ink or digital signature) by the institution's legal representative indicating their name, function, email address and, in case of blue ink signature, along with the stamp of the institution.

⁶³ [Commission Recommendation 2005/251/EC of 11 March 2005](#) on the European Charter for Researchers included in Annex II to the Council Recommendation of 18 December 2023 on a European framework to attract and retain research,

transparent recruitment processes based on merit and career development — and ensure that the principal investigator, researchers and third parties involved in the action are aware of them;

- c) enter — before grant signature— into a Supplementary Agreement with the principal investigator, that specifies the obligation of the applicant legal entity to meet its obligations under the Agreement;
- d) provide the principal investigator with a copy of the signed Agreement;
- e) guarantee the principal investigator scientific independence, in particular for the:
 - i) use of the budget to achieve the scientific objectives;
 - ii) authority to publish as senior author and invite as co-authors those who have contributed substantially to the work;
 - iii) preparation of scientific reports for the action;
 - iv) selection and supervision of the other team members, in line with the profiles needed to conduct the research and in accordance with the beneficiary's usual management practices;
 - v) possibility to apply independently for funding;
 - vi) access to appropriate space and facilities for conducting the research;
- f) provide — during the implementation of the action — research support to the principal investigator and the team members (regarding infrastructure, equipment, access rights, products and other services necessary for conducting the research);
- g) support the principal investigator and provide administrative assistance, in particular for the:
 - i) general management of the work and their team;
 - ii) scientific reporting, especially ensuring that the team members send their scientific results to the principal investigator;
 - iii) financial reporting, especially providing timely and clear financial information;
 - iv) application of the beneficiary's usual management practices;
 - v) general logistics of the action;
 - vi) access to the electronic exchange system;
- h) inform the principal investigator immediately (in writing) of any events or circumstances likely to affect the Agreement;
- i) ensure that the principal investigator enjoys adequate:
 - i) conditions for annual, sickness and parental leave;
 - ii) occupational health and safety standards;
 - iii) insurance under the general social security scheme, such as pension rights;
- j) allow the transfer of the Agreement to a new beneficiary, if requested by the principal investigator and provided that the objectives of the action remain achievable (portability; see Article 41 of the Agreement);
- k) respect the fundamental principle of research integrity and ensure that persons carrying out research tasks under the action follow the good research practices and refrain from the research integrity violations described in the European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity⁶⁴. If any such violations or allegations occur, verify and pursue them and bring them to the attention of the Agency.

innovation and entrepreneurial talents in Europe and on a Code of Conduct for the Recruitment of Researchers (OJ L 75, 22.3.2005, p. 67).

⁶⁴ [The European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity](#) – Revised Edition 2023. All European Academies, Berlin. DOI 10.26356/ECOC

For the applicant legal entity (host institution):

Date



Name and Function



Email and legally binding signature of legal representative



Stamp of the applicant legal entity (host institution)⁶⁵

IMPORTANT NOTE:

In order to be complete, all the above-mentioned items are mandatory and shall be included in the commitment of the host institution.

If the letter is digitally signed, please do NOT lock it. Locked files cannot be uploaded to the submission portal.

⁶⁵ No need to stamp this letter of support when it is digitally signed.

4.3 PHD AND EQUIVALENT DOCTORAL DEGREES

The ERC Policy on PhD and equivalent doctoral degrees is detailed in Annex 2 of the [ERC Work Programme 2027](#) 'ERC Policy on PhD and equivalent doctoral degrees':

1. The necessity of ascertaining PhD equivalence

In order to be eligible to apply to the ERC Starting or Consolidator Grant, a Principal Investigator must have successfully defended a PhD or equivalent doctoral degree. First-professional degrees will not be considered in themselves as PhD-equivalent, even if recipients carry the title "Doctor". See below for further guidelines on PhD degree equivalency.

2. PhD Degrees

The research doctorate is the highest earned academic degree. It is always awarded for **independent research** at a professional level in either academic disciplines or professional fields. Regardless of the entry point, doctoral studies involve several stages of academic work. These may include the completion of preliminary course, seminar and laboratory studies and/or the passing of a battery of written examinations. The PhD candidate selects an academic adviser and a subject for the dissertation, is assigned a dissertation committee, and designs their research (some educators call the doctoral thesis a dissertation to distinguish it from lesser theses). The dissertation committee consists usually of 3-5 faculty members in the candidate's research field, including the adviser.

3. Independent research

Conducting the research and writing the dissertation usually requires one to several years depending upon the topic selected and the research work necessary to prepare the dissertation. In defending their thesis, **the PhD candidate must establish mastery of the subject matter, explain and justify their research findings, and answer all questions put by the committee.** A successful defence results in the award of the PhD degree.

4. Degrees equivalent to the PhD:

It is recognised that there are some other doctoral titles that enjoy the same status and represent variants of the PhD in certain fields. All of them have **similar content requirements**. Potential applicants are invited to consult the following for useful references on degrees that will be considered equivalent to the PhD:

- EURYDICE: "Examinations, qualifications and titles - Second edition, Volume 1, European glossary on education" published in 2004⁶⁶. Please note that some titles that belong to the same category with doctoral degrees (ISCED 6 – 1997 classification or ISCED 8 – 2011 classification⁶⁷) may correspond to the intermediate steps towards the completion of doctoral education and they should not be therefore considered as PhD-equivalent.
- List of research doctorate titles awarded in the United States that enjoy the same status and represent variants of the PhD within certain fields. These doctorate titles are also recognised as PhD-equivalent by the U.S. National Science Foundation (NSF).

⁶⁶ <http://bookshop.europa.eu/en/european-glossary-on-education-pbEC3212292/>.

⁶⁷ <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000219109.locale=en>

5. First Professional Degrees (for applicants holding a degree in medicine please see below):

It is important to recognise that the initial professional degrees in various fields are **first degrees, not graduate research degrees**. Several degree titles in such fields include the term "Doctor", **but they are neither research doctorates nor equivalent to the PhD**.

6. Applicants holding a degree in medicine:

A first degree in medicine will not be accepted by itself as equivalent to a PhD degree. To be considered an eligible Principal Investigator, applicants holding a degree in medicine need to provide **the certificates of both the medical degree and the PhD or proof of an appointment that requires doctoral equivalency** (e.g. post-doctoral fellowship, professorship appointment). Additionally, candidates must also provide information on their research experience (including peer reviewed publications) in order to further substantiate the equivalence of their overall training to a PhD.

In these cases, the certified date of the medical degree completion plus two years is the reference date used for the calculation of the eligibility period established for Starting and Consolidator Grants in the section "Eligible Principal investigator(s)" of the ERC Work programme 2027.

For applicants holding both a degree in medicine and a PhD, **the date used for the calculation of the eligibility period** (i.e. medical degree plus two years or the date of the successful defence of their PhD degree) **is the date of the earliest degree that makes the applicant eligible**.

Further explanation on point 6 for applicants holding several degrees:

A medical degree⁶⁸ takes precedence over a PhD degree **only** when an applicant has held an appointment that requires doctoral equivalency (e.g. post-doctoral fellowship, professorship appointment) **before** the date of successful defence of a PhD.

Example 1

A Principal Investigator who was awarded a degree in medicine in 2010, completed clinical specialty training in 2015 and then defended a PhD on 1 January 2020, is eligible to apply to the Starting or Consolidator Grant 2027 call based on the date of the successful defence of the PhD. As the medical degree by itself is not accepted as equivalent to a PhD award, the earliest eligible degree is the PhD – defended 7 years prior to 1 January 2027 and within the eligibility window of both calls (0 – 10 years and 5 – 15 years after PhD, respectively).

Example 2

A Principal Investigator who was awarded a degree in medicine on 1 January 2006, completed a 3-year clinical training in 2009 and held one or several research positions requiring PhD equivalence (e.g. post-doctoral fellowship or professorship appointment) prior to successfully defending a PhD in 2020, is ineligible for both the Starting and Consolidator Grant 2027 calls. The medical degree together with the research experience acquired during the research position(s) is considered equivalent to a PhD. Therefore, the earliest eligible degree is the medical degree – awarded 21 years prior to 1 January 2027 and not within the eligibility window (the date of the medical degree + 2 years = 1 January 2008, is used for the calculation of the eligibility window of 0-10 years for STG and 5-15 years for COG). An extension for three years of clinical training is not enough to make the applicant eligible for the Consolidator Grant call.

⁶⁸ The basic medical degree (first graduate degree in medicine) applicable to all countries.

Example 3

A Principal Investigator who was awarded a medical degree on 1 January 2016, followed by a Dr. Med. degree awarded on 11 July 2019 and who then held one or several research positions requiring PhD equivalence (e.g. post-doctoral fellowship or professorship appointment) is eligible to apply to both the Starting and Consolidator Grant 2027 calls based on the award date of the medical degree. As the Dr. Med. degree by itself is not accepted as equivalent to a PhD degree, the earliest eligible degree is the MD degree – awarded 11 years prior to 1 January 2027 and within the eligibility window (the date of the medical degree + 2 years = 1 January 2018, is used for the calculation of the eligibility window of 0-10 years for STG and 5-15 years for COG). The certified date of the MD degree completion plus two years is the time reference for calculation of the eligibility time-window and thus 1 January 2018 is the PhD equivalence date, which should be entered in the application form for this applicant.

Example 4

A Principal Investigator who was awarded an MD Univ. degree on 8 August 2009, followed by a Dr. Med. degree awarded on 25 October 2010 and then defended a PhD on 1 January 2014 is eligible to apply to the Consolidator Grant 2027 call based on the defence date of the PhD degree. As the Dr. Med. degree by itself is not accepted as equivalent to a PhD award, and as the applicant has not held any research positions requiring PhD equivalence between the MD Univ. degree and the PhD, the earliest eligible degree is the PhD degree – successfully defended 13 years prior to 1 January 2027 and within the eligibility window (5 – 15 years past PhD) for Consolidator grant applicants.

4.4 SUPPORTING DOCUMENTS FOR THE PHD REFERENCE DATE AND EXTENSION REQUESTS

The date of the PhD considered for the calculation of the eligibility period is the date of the successful defence of the first PhD degree.

The eligibility periods for STG and COG calls can be extended beyond 10 and 15 years for the Starting and Consolidator Grants, respectively, for the following properly documented circumstances⁶⁹ or events.

Unless otherwise specified, extensions to the eligibility period can only be granted for circumstances or events that have occurred or were present in the period following the Principal Investigator's PhD Defence Date up until the deadline of the respective call for proposals.

*- **Maternity:** an 18-month extension per child⁷⁰ born before or after the Principal Investigator's PhD Defence Date. If an applicant can demonstrate a longer period of leave (i.e. maternity leave or maternity leave combined with parental leave), the eligibility period shall be extended by the total duration of actual leave taken.*

*- **Paternity or parental leave:** extension by the documented amount of paternity or parental leave (or a combination thereof) taken for each child⁷² born before or after the Principal Investigator's PhD Defence Date.*

*- **Long-term illness⁷¹ or national service:** extension by the documented amount of leave taken by the Principal Investigator for each occurrence.*

*- **Disability⁷²:** Extension corresponding to the reduced amount of working time (including leave taken) and/or the degree of disability of the Principal Investigator.*

*- **Clinical training:** extension by the documented duration of clinical training (up to a maximum of 4 years) received by the Principal Investigator.*

*- **Major disasters⁷³:** extension by the documented duration of the Principal Investigator's inability to work⁷⁴ resulting from a major disaster.*

*- **Seeking Asylum:** extension by the documented time of the Principal Investigator's inability to work due to seeking asylum⁷⁵.*

*- **Gender-based Violence or Any Other Form of Violence⁷⁶:** extension by the documented duration of the Principal Investigator's inability to work⁷⁶ due to being a victim of violence.*

⁶⁹ For applicants whose first eligible degree is their medical degree such circumstances or events can be considered from the date of completion of their medical degree.

⁷⁰ This equally applies to cases where the applicant is the main caregiver of an adopted child.

⁷¹ Long-term illness is understood as a period over 90 days for the Principal Investigator or a close family member.

⁷² Persons with disabilities include those who have long-term physical, mental, intellectual or sensory impairments which in interaction with various barriers may hinder their full and effective participation in society on an equal basis with others (UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD)). Request for eligibility extension for disability-related reasons can also be indicated for cases where working capacity was reduced due to disability.

⁷³ Major disasters include large-scale geological (e.g. earthquakes), meteorological (e.g. floods) or human-caused (e.g. armed conflicts) events that cause loss of life or property.

⁷⁴ For a minimum of 90 days.

⁷⁵ The possible period of extension runs from the start date of asylum/refugee application to the date of decision on the applicant Principal Investigator's refugee status or the receipt of the residence permit.

In case the PhD certificate does not show the date of defence of the PhD, the applicant should provide an official confirmation from the awarding institution of the date of the successful defence of their PhD. If the PhD defence was not successful and following the PhD defence, corrections were required, applicants should provide an official document indicating that the defence was not successful and a date when the corrections to the PhD thesis were approved.

In case no defence was organised, the Principal Investigator should provide an official confirmation from the awarding institution that no defence was required (not part of the PhD programme) and stating a date when the PhD was approved (similar to a defence date; i.e. an approval date before the PhD was awarded).

The official transcript of the PhD course noting any of the dates above is also acceptable.

All applicants are entitled to an extension of their eligibility window if properly documented and related to the specific circumstances defined in the annual ERC Work Programme⁷⁷. Please note that any such circumstance must have started before the call deadline. The reference date for calculating the eligibility window is the reference date of the first eligible degree according to the national rules of the awarding country. The extension time is calculated based on the supporting documentation submitted with the application. There is no limit to the total extension timeframe. Please note however, that a maximum of 4 years has been introduced for extensions due to clinical training. The individual extensions for different periods are additive and the total extension time can thus be based on several reasons.

Maternity leave

For maternity⁷⁸, a flat rate of 18 months extension is granted for each child born **before or after** the PhD defence. In case of one child, if a maternity leave or the combined maternity and parental leave was longer than 18 months, an extension will be granted for the documented leave actually taken. In case of more than one child, if the maternity leaves or the combined maternity and parental leaves were longer than the total flat rate, an extension will be granted for the documented leave(s) actually taken. The eligibility period shall be calculated based either on the flat rate or on the actual duration, whichever is longest; thus, where an extension is requested for several children, the calculation will be based either on the flat rate or the total duration of actual leave taken (i.e. one cannot claim a flat rate for one child and the actual duration for another). The same principle also applies for child adoption.

Supporting documents: any official document that links the mother and the child(ren), i.e. birth certificate(s) or passport(s) of the child(ren) or family book. For extension requests above the flat rate, an official signed document⁷⁹ from the employer certifying start and end dates of the individual leave(s) must be submitted. Any document should mention the reason for the leave. If the leave was conducted as a part-time leave, this should be stated. It is acceptable if the time off work happened over several periods.

A couple of examples are provided below to further clarify the guidance for maternity leave-based extension requests:

Example 1:

A Principal Investigator has two children. She took a maternity leave of 4 months for the first child and 6 months for the second child. She also took part-time parental leave at 50% during two years. In

⁷⁶ Any action with the intention to cause physical or psychological harm to another person.

⁷⁷ E.g. no extension to the eligibility window can be accepted for periods of unemployment.

⁷⁸ Different family and couple scenarios can be considered provided they are properly documented

⁷⁹ The certificate should be issued by a person within the employing organisation empowered to certify the actual leave taken (i.e. an authorised officer from the HR Department).

this case, the total documented leave would be 4 months + 6 months + 12 months (2 years * 50 %) = 22 months. The flat rate, which is 18 months per child born before or after the PhD award, would be 2 * 18 months = 36 months. As the flat rate gives a longer extension than the accumulated documented leaves taken, the Principal Investigator would be given the 36 months of flat rate as an extension to the eligibility reference date.

Example 2:

A Principal Investigator has two children. She took a maternity leave of 6 months for the first child and 10 months for the second child. She also took full-time parental leave during two years. In this case, the total documented leave would be 6 months + 10 months + 24 months = 40 months. The flat rate, which is 18 months per child born before or after the PhD award, would be 2 * 18 months = 36 months. As the total documented leaves taken corresponds to a longer extension than the flat rate, the Principal Investigator would be given the 40 months of documented leaves taken as an extension to the eligibility reference date.

Paternity or parental leave

For paternity leave or parental leave, an extension will be granted corresponding to the documented time of paternity and/or parental leave actually taken for each child born **before or after** the PhD defence (counting up until the call deadline). Both full time and part time leaves can be accepted if properly documented⁸⁰. The same principle also applies for child adoption.

Supporting documents: an official signed document⁷⁹ from the employer certifying start and end dates of the individual leave(s). Any document should mention the reason for the leave. If the leave was conducted as a part-time leave, this should be stated. It is acceptable if the time off work happened over several periods.

Long-term illness

For long-term illness (more than 90 days⁸¹ for the Principal Investigator or a close family member such as a child, spouse, parent or sibling), an extension can be granted corresponding to the documented time of leave actually taken after the PhD defence (counting up until the call deadline). Full time and part time leaves as well as reduced working capacity can be accepted if properly documented.

. Applicants do not need to provide any details regarding the nature of the illness itself, but it should be clear from the supporting documentation that the illness lasted more than 90 days (even if the total leave related to illness was in total less than 90 days).

Supporting documents:

- For the Principal Investigator: an official, signed document from the employer certifying start and end dates of the individual leave(s) or a medical record that indicates work incapability with the start and end dates of the illness period(s). Any document should mention the reason for the leave. If the leave was conducted as a part-time leave, this should be stated. It is acceptable if the time off work happened over several periods, as long as the leaves were related to the same illness or condition. Furthermore, the request should be supported by an official document explaining the long-term nature of the illness or condition (e.g. from a hospital, a doctor or an insurance company).

⁸⁰ An official document proving the Principal Investigator's right to social paternity benefits can also be accepted.

⁸¹ The illness needs to be longer than 90 days and not the leave taken (the leave or cumulated leaves taken can be of shorter duration).

- For taking care of close family members: an official signed document from the employer certifying start and end dates of the individual leave(s). Any document should mention the reason for the leave. If the leave was conducted as a part-time leave, this should be stated. It is acceptable if the time off work happened over several periods, as long as the leaves were related to the same illness or condition. Furthermore, the request should be supported by an official document explaining the long-term nature of the illness or condition of the close family member (e.g. from a hospital, a doctor or an insurance company). The supporting documents should also prove the family relationship in case the extension request relates to caring for a seriously ill close family member.

National (military) service

For national (military) service⁸², an extension can be granted corresponding to the documented amount of leave actually taken after the PhD defence (counting up until the call deadline).

Supporting documents: document signed by official authority with start and end date of the service.

Disability

Extension corresponding to the reduced amount of working time (including leave taken) and/or the degree⁸³ of disability of the Principal Investigator.

Supporting documents: an official document confirming the disability together with documentation certifying leave/part-time working/reduced working capacity resulting from the disability, with relevant start and end dates (if applicable). Any document should mention the reason for the leave.

Clinical training

For clinical training, an extension can be granted corresponding to the documented time of clinical training received by the Principal Investigator after the first eligible degree up to a maximum of 4 years (counting up until the call deadline). For applicants whose first eligible degree is a medical degree, clinical training can be accepted from the date of the completion of their medical degree. No extension will be accepted for serving as a house doctor or hospital doctor unless it is part of a clinical training programme. In case of part-time clinical training, the exact total training time will be accepted on a pro-rata basis to extend the eligibility window of the applicant.

Supporting documents: an official document signed by the employer (usually a hospital) certifying start and end dates of the individual training period(s). Any document should mention the type of training. If the training was conducted part-time, this should be stated. It is acceptable if the training happened over several periods and for different clinical specialties.

Major disasters

An extension can be granted corresponding to the documented time of a Principal Investigator's inability to work for a minimum of 90 days before the call deadline for events related to major disasters (large-scale geological (e.g. earthquakes), meteorological (e.g. floods) or human-caused

⁸² The national service would be a compulsory military service/any other service to replace the military service. This could also be extended to other national service of a compulsory nature which in principle cannot be declined by a person.

⁸³ In some countries, it is possible to have the disability officially recognized by the government. In such cases there is sometimes a degree of disability (e.g. in percentage) that comes with the official recognition. With such a document, an extension would be calculated as for the reduced working capacity, taking into account the degree of disability.

(e.g. armed conflicts) events that cause loss of life or property)⁸⁴. This inability must have occurred after the date of the successful defence of their PhD degree and before the call deadline.

Supporting documents: An official, signed document from the employer certifying start and end date(s) of the inability or reduced capacity to work due to a major disaster. Any document should mention the reason for the interruption.

Seeking Asylum:

An extension can be granted corresponding to the documented time of the Principal Investigator's inability to work before the call deadline due to seeking asylum, which occurred after the date of the successful defence of their PhD degree. The possible period of extension runs from the start date of asylum/refugee application to the date of decision on the applicant Principal Investigator's refugee status and/or receipt of specific residence permit.

Supporting documents: an official, signed document from the competent authorities confirming the Principal Investigator's inability to work due to seeking asylum indicating a start date of asylum/refugee application and a date of the decision on the applicant Principal Investigator's refugee status and/or receipt of specific residence permit. This information can be provided within several documents. An official document proving the Acknowledgement of receipt of the request/application for the asylum /refugee status could be also accepted.

Gender-based Violence or any other form of violence:

An extension can be granted corresponding to the documented time of the Principal Investigator's inability to work for a minimum of 90 days before the call deadline due to gender-based violence or any other form of violence⁷⁸, which occurred after the date of the successful defence of their PhD degree.

Supporting documents: an official, signed document from a competent authority (e.g. hospital, Police, employer) confirming the Principal Investigator's inability to work due to any form of violence indicating start and end dates of full-time incapacity to work or reduced working capacity.

⁸⁴ Please note that inability to work due to Covid-19- related lockdown and constraints per se is not considered as a reason for extension.

4.5 ADDITIONAL SECURITY CONDITIONS FOR ELIGIBILITY

Annex 3 of the [ERC Work Programme 2027](#) details additional eligibility conditions applicable to entities involved in applications to the ERC. These conditions allow the ERCEA to ensure that entities subjected to restrictions regarding their ability to receive EU funding (because of various policy considerations, e.g. they are listed in a sanctions list) do not participate in ERC funded research.

In the case of Starting and Consolidator Grants calls, entities complying with any of the conditions below cannot participate in ERC funded projects:

- Entities subject to EU restrictive measures under Article 29 of the Treaty on the European Union (TEU) and Article 215 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the EU (TFEU), as well as Article 75 TFEU⁸⁵.
- Legal entities established in Russia, Belarus, or in non-government-controlled territories of Ukraine, even where such entities are not subject to EU restrictive measures.
- Legal entities established outside Russia but whose proprietary rights are directly or indirectly owned for more than 50% by a legal person, entity or body established in Russia.
- Hungarian public interest trusts established under Hungarian Act IX of 2021 or any entity they maintain.
- Entities covered by the Commission Guidelines on the eligibility of Israeli entities and their activities in the territories occupied by Israel since June 1967 for grants, prizes and financial instruments funded by the EU from 2014 onwards⁸⁶.
- Entities that are assessed as high-risk suppliers of mobile network communication equipment (and any entities they may own or control) in projects involving technologies linked to the development of the European Telecommunications networks.

The ERCEA verifies the applicability of these special eligibility conditions during the early stages of the Grant Agreement Preparation process. They do not affect the scientific evaluation of proposals. Proposals involving entities potentially falling under any of the abovementioned conditions can be submitted. Beneficiaries may be requested to provide additional information and documentation as part of the verification process.

In case the involvement of an ineligible entity is confirmed, remedial actions will be requested by the ERCEA. These range from the removal or replacement of the ineligible entity (if it is an additional entity and not the Host Institution), to the transfer of the applying Principal Investigator to a new eligible legal entity (when the ineligible entity is the applying Host Institution), in line with the principle of portability

Additional details on this can be found in Annex 3 of the Work Programme.

⁸⁵ www.sanctionsmap.eu Please note that the sanctions map is an IT tool for identifying the sanctions regimes. The source of the sanctions stems from legal acts published in the Official Journal (OJ). In case of discrepancy between the published legal acts and the updates on the website, it is the OJ version that prevails.

⁸⁶ OJ C 205, 19.7.2013, p. 9.

4.6 LIST OF BLOCKING FIELDS IN THE ONLINE SUBMISSION FORM

BLOCKING FIELDS: The submission of the proposal will be blocked unless the error/missing entry is corrected

Section General Information

Acronym

Title

Duration

Primary ERC Review Panel

ERC Keyword 1

Abstract

Previous submission of similar proposal – yes/no

Section Declarations

All declarations must be confirmed

Section: Participants

PI: First name, Last name and e-Mail (can only be entered at Step 4/Participants in the submission system)

PI: Nationality, Date of birth, Gender, Country of birth, Place of birth, Town and Country.

Main contact person (for ERC HI contact person): contact First name, Last name and e-Mail (can only be entered at Step 4/ in the submission system).

Section: Budget

Total Eligible Costs and Requested EU contribution per beneficiary

Total budget should be greater than 0

The total Requested EU contribution should not be zero

Section: Ethics and security

No blocking fields

Section: Other questions

Date of earliest award (PhD or equivalent)

Percentage of working time in an EU Member State or Associated Country over the period of the grant

Percentage of working time the PI dedicates to the project over the period of the grant

Declaration of eligibility requirements Confirmation of written consent obtained from participants and researchers

Consents on permission on sharing evaluation data. These data-related consents are entirely voluntary

WARNINGS: The submission of the proposal will not be blocked

Section: General Information

Previous submission of similar proposal (if created and left empty)

Section: Participants

PI: ORCID number, Career Stage, Last name at Birth, Title, Country of residence, Contact address

Contact address of HI and contact person: Gender, Position in org., Department

Section: Budget

Resources section (if not enough characters)

Section: Ethics

Declaration of assessment of ethics issues

4.7 PROPOSAL BUDGET REPORT⁸⁷

Proposal number	999999
Acronym	ERC proposal
Title	Title describing the ERC proposal
Evaluation panel	XXx
Principal Investigator	First Name, Last Name
Host institution	Name of host institution, country
Project duration	xx months (this information will be extracted from the administrative form, section 1 - General information)
Time commitment of the PI to the project	xx% (this information will be extracted from the administrative form, section 5 - Other questions)

Budget summary

Beneficiary organisation(s)	Total cost (€)	Requested AMT (€)
1. Name of Institution, country	x,xxx,xxx.00	xxx,xxx.00

Budget details

Cost Category / Beneficiary			Name of Institution	Total
A. Personnel costs	PI		xx	Xx
	Senior Staff		xx	Xx
	Postdocs		xx	Xx
	Students		xx	Xx
	Other Personnel costs		xx	Xx
Total Personnel costs			Xxx	Xxx
B. Subcontracting costs (no indirect costs)			xx	Xx
C. Purchase costs	C.1 Travel and subsistence		xx	Xx
	C.2. Equipment incl. major equipment		xx	Xx
	C.3 Other goods, works and services	Consumables incl. fieldwork and animal costs	xx	Xx
		Publications (incl. Open Access fees) and dissemination	xx	Xx
		Other additional direct costs	xx	Xx
		C.3 Total other goods, works and services	Xx	Xx
Total Purchase costs (C1 + C2 + C3)			Xxx	Xxx
D. Internally invoiced goods and services (no indirect costs)			Xx	Xx
E. Indirect costs (= 25% * (A + C1 + C2 + C3))			Xxx	Xxx
Total eligible costs (A + B + C + D + E)			X.xxx.xxx	X.xxx.xxx
Requested EU contribution			X.XXX.XXX	X.XXX.XXX

⁸⁷ This is an example of how the Proposal Budget Report looks like for the experts. Please note that the layout may be further adapted when needed.

Resources

I plan to allocate (one to max. two descriptive text pages) – max. 8000 characters.

This section and the budget table will be made available to the experts evaluating the proposal at Step 2. Important: your description of resources will be truncated once it exceeds the maximum allowed characters. Please make sure that your description is complete within the characters limit before submitting.

State and fully justify the amount of funding considered necessary to fulfil the objectives for the duration of the project. The project cost estimation should be as accurate as possible. The evaluation panels assess the estimated costs carefully; unjustified budgets will be consequently reduced. Please specify if you will use third parties giving in-kind contributions to the action.

If applicable, please specify the cost items covered by your 'Other personnel costs' category and the cost items covered by your 'Other additional direct costs' category.

Request for additional funding if applicable (All items MUST be included in the overall budget table above, in the appropriate cost category): xxx (Cost in EUR).

Justification:

4.8 TEMPLATE FOR REQUESTING ELIGIBILITY EXTENSION

If you are requesting an extension of the eligibility period, this request should be uploaded as Annex 1 of the application (**in a single PDF document containing a cover page and all supporting documents**). For information on the circumstances that could justify such an extension and the type of documents supporting this request please see [section 4.4](#) of this document.

The cover page should include the following information:

ELIGIBILITY EXTENSION REQUEST

In connection with my proposal [*call identifier: STG 2027/ COG 2027*] acronym [*indicate acronym*], I am requesting an extension of the eligibility window period due to:

- ☐ **Maternity /parental leave**
- ☐ **Paternity / parental leave**
- ☐ **Long-term illness⁸⁸**
- ☐ **National service**
- ☐ **Disability**
- ☐ **Clinical training**
- ☐ **Major disaster⁸⁹**
- ☐ **Seeking asylum**
- ☐ **Gender-based Violence or any other form of Violence⁸⁹**

Calculation of the extension period for the applicable circumstances [*each event should be listed separately*]:

No.	Leave/event	[if applicable] Short description (e.g. taking care of a sick family member)	Start date (not needed for a flat rate)	End date (not needed for a flat rate)	Calculated number of days/months/ years	Supporting document(s) (type)
1.						
2.						
3.						
Total extension request [<i>1+2+3+(...)</i>]:						

⁸⁸ Over 90 days for the Principal Investigator or a close family member (child, spouse, parent or sibling).

⁸⁹ For a minimum of 90 days.

4.9 TEMPLATE TO BE FILLED IN BY THE PHD AWARDING INSTITUTION CONFIRMING THE PHD DEFENCE DATE

Please use this template to attest to the date of your first PhD successful defence/viva, if it is not clearly mentioned in the diploma or any other official document and upload it with your application. Please note that if the PhD defence date is the same as the award date but this is not clearly stated, the defence date must still be confirmed by the awarding Institution. The template should be filled in and signed with a legally binding signature (e.g. blue ink or digital signature) by the awarding institution.

Confirmation of PhD defence date

- ☐ PhD defence took place and it was successful:

The <<please fill in the name of the PhD awarding institution >>, which is the PhD awarding institution, confirms that <<please fill in the name of the principal investigator>> successfully defended their doctoral degree on <<please fill in the date of the PhD successful defence date>>.

- ☐ PhD defence took place, but it was unsuccessful or its approval was conditional on the completion of corrections. The date indicated below is when the corrections to the PhD thesis were approved.

The <<please fill in the name of the PhD awarding institution >>, which is the PhD awarding institution, confirms that the PhD thesis/PhD degree of <<please fill in here the name of the principal investigator>> was approved on <<please fill in the date recorded by the institution in the absence of a defence>>, following the completion of the required corrections.

- ☐ No PhD defence took place, as it is not part of the PhD programme.

The <<please fill in the name of the PhD awarding institution >>, which is the PhD awarding institution, confirms that the PhD thesis/PhD degree of <<please fill in here the name of the principal investigator>> was approved on <<please fill in the date recorded by the institution in the absence of a defence>>.

In case any further information must be provided by the awarding institution, they can do so below in free text.

Date

.....

Name and Function

.....

Email and legally binding signature

.....

4.10 DATA PROTECTION NOTICE

All [legal notices](#) are accessible on the F&T Portal.

The Privacy Statement on 'Grant management and registration/validation of participants' relevant to this document is available [here](#).